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CONG TO EXPAND ITS OUTREACH TO STUDENTS, TEMPLE TRUST PROTESTS

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NEW DELHI: The Congress Working Committee (CWC) said on Wednesday it would double down on the party's outreach to students by extending Leader of the Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi's "Chhatron ki Goonj" programme to 800 towns, launch a grassroots agitation against alleged donation theft at the Ram Mandir and resolved not to sing the full version of the national song Vande Mataram at party events.

Party chief Mallikarjun Kharge asked Congress-led state governments to consult experts to prepare a blueprint for education and exam reforms in their respective states. →P5

NCERT REVAMPS CLASS 11 AND 12 POLITICAL SCIENCE TEXTBOOK PANEL

Press Trust of India

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NEW DELHI: The NCERT has reconstituted the Textbook Development Team for class 11 and 12 political science with a mandate to integrate cultural rootedness, Indian knowledge systems and inclusion, with at least four of the members having direct or indirect links with the RSS.

The team has been asked to develop the class 11 textbook by November and the class 12 book by July next year.

The textbook team will be led by academic and political analyst Sandeep Shastri, vice president of Karnataka-based deemed university NITTE. →P5

SC asks NTA where things stand on '24 exam reforms plan

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Wednesday asked the Union government to present details of its implementation of the recommendations of the K Radhakrishnan committee, constituted in the aftermath of the NEET-UG 2024 controversy, along with a definite timeline, stressing that it was more concerned with institutionalising the National Testing Agency (NTA) than merely putting in place security protocols on paper.

A bench of justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhe, hearing petitions related to the NEET UG 2026 paper leak, directed the Union government to file an affidavit detailing the steps taken to implement the Radhakrishnan committee's recommendations, as "reflected and nuanced" by the high-powered task force headed by Infosys co-founder Nandan Nilekani, and give indicative timelines for their implementation.

As part of its efforts to address the 2026 paper leak, the Union government set up a committee headed by Nilekani to address systemic issues; it has also sought to strengthen NTA, by creating new senior level positions, including for security. The Radhakrishnan committee was set up in the wake of a similar controversy two years ago, and

continued on →9

Implementation in progress

2 years after NEET leak panel was formed, key fixes remain

WHAT'S BEEN DONE

- NTA restructuring — domain-specific leadership, psychometric expertise (rolled out this year, after protests)
- 16 new permanent posts advertised at NTA; specialist hires in cybersecurity, digital forensics, assessment research and test-centre operations
- Strengthened frisking and repeat biometric verification after bio-breaks, tighter candidate verification

ANNOUNCED BUT NOT ROLLED OUT

- Multi-session testing for large examinations
- Multi-stage format for NEET-UG
- Shift of NEET-UG to a computer-based, multi-session format

WHAT HASN'T BEEN DONE

- DIGI-EXAM identity verification system
- Hybrid, computer-assisted secure question-paper transmission
- Collaborations with global testing agencies

The core recommendation that NTA stop conducting recruitment tests and focus on entrance exams has not been implemented. 21 of the panel's 41 long-term structural reforms remain untouched, an HT analysis found.

J'KHAND: 26-DAY STIR CALLED OFF AFTER EXAMS CANCELLED

The 26-day stir over alleged irregularities in Jharkhand's recruitment exams was suspended on Wednesday, with protesters giving the Hemant Soren government two months to address their grievances, even as those fearing job loss over exam cancellations moved the high court. The decision was announced by the student representatives, who called the move "a strategic pause" to see if the government fulfils its promises and warned of protesting again if it falls short. →P5

NTA TIGHTENS NORMS TO HIRE EXPERTS

Teachers who want to serve as subject experts for examinations conducted by NTA will have to submit multiple documents, including employment records and a no-objection certificate from their current employer. →P5

COURT SEEKS DETAILS OF NILEKANI TASK FORCE'S MANDATE

The Supreme Court bench hearing the NEET paper leak case sought clarity on the role of the Nandan Nilekani-led task force, which was constituted last month to overhaul India's exam system. →P9

IRAN WARNS GULF STATES AFTER UAE SNAPS TRADE TIES

TEHRAN: Iran's armed forces warned Gulf countries against assisting the US military on Wednesday, hours after the UAE announced it was severing economic ties with Tehran following new attacks on shipping. Iranian armed forces chief of staff Ali Abdollahi, according to the state-affiliated Mehr news agency, warned "any assistance or facilitation provided to the aggressor US military amounts to participation in the US military operation". →P11

DELHI DRAFT VOTER ROLL DELAYED, TO BE OUT ON AUG 31

NEW DELHI: The Election Commission revised the schedule for the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in Delhi on Wednesday, postponing key stages of the exercise by a week and the publication of the final electoral roll by eight days, from August 24 to 31, said people aware of the matter. Officials said the dates have been revised since the rationalisation exercise of polling stations is not yet complete. HT

MINISTERS TOLD TO SCALE UP SOCIAL MEDIA OUTREACH

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NEW DELHI: Members of the Union Council of Ministers received an analysis of their engagement on social media during Wednesday's cabinet meeting chaired by PM Narendra Modi and were also given instructions to scale up outreach, said people aware of the matter. →P7

3 die as truck's CNG tank explodes at Delhi pump

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NEW DELHI: Three people were killed and three injured when a truck's gas tank exploded while being refilled at a CNG pump in Tikri Kalan on Delhi's north-western fringes on Wednesday, said police.

The three dead were identified as Manish Prasad (26), Sunny (30), and Brahmjeet (34) — all staffers at the Indraprastha Gas Limited (IGL) pump. The injured were identified as Surjeet (32), Sanjay (37), and Vipin (30), the driver of the truck.

The trigger for the explosion was not immediately clear, said investigators.

Police and IGL personnel inspected the spot to draw up the sequence of events. Police



The trigger for the explosion is not yet known, said investigators. HT

said a case of negligence under Section 106 of the Bharatiya Nyay Sanhita (BNS) would be lodged and the dealer questioned.

A senior IGL officer said the

station, on Rohtak Road, near Tikri Kalan Metro station, is owned and operated by Aadhya Energies. The company, said the officer, is owned by Himanshu

continued on →9

Gor's J&K visit triggers Pakistan spat with US

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NEW DELHI: US ambassador Sergio Gor on Wednesday described Jammu and Kashmir as an "important part of India" during a visit to Srinagar, prompting Pakistan to summon the senior-most American diplomat in Islamabad to register a protest.

Gor, the first US ambassador to travel to Jammu and Kashmir in six years, made the remarks after a meeting with chief minister Omar Abdullah. He also indicated that the US could look into downgrading a travel advisory for Kashmir in view of the improvement in the situation in the region. "This is



J&K CM Omar Abdullah with US Ambassador Sergio Gor. ANI

an important part of India and so I am here visiting for the first time. It is an incredibly beautiful place and I'm thrilled to be here, thrilled to see this place," Gor said while speaking to the local media along with Abdullah. →P7

RIJUJU: CONFUSION ARISES AS BORDER WITH CHINA NOT DEMARCATED

NEW DELHI: Parliamentary affairs minister Kiren Rijiju has said people living on either side of the LAC in some areas of Arunachal Pradesh have differing perceptions of the boundary because it is not demarcated, leading to some confusion. He trashed reports suggesting China had intruded 60km into Indian territory. "Our

people believe that our land extends further ahead, while the villages situated on the China side... claim that their land extends deep inside here..." he told news agency IANS. →P7

5 Bangladeshis among nine dead in Kolkata hotel blaze

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KOLKATA: Five Bangladeshi nationals, including a three-year-old boy, were among nine people killed after a fire broke out at a hotel on the second floor of a five-storey building on Mirza Ghalib Street in central Kolkata on Wednesday, officials said.

The blaze broke out around 2am at Shikha Inn, one of several small hotels operating from the building at 15H Mirza Ghalib Street. Officials suspect a short circuit triggered the fire.

Police and fire officials said the building housed multiple hotels and guest houses with small rooms and inadequate fire-safety arrangements. "The rooms in these hotels were small and most of them didn't have any window or ventilation. There was hardly any fire-alarm or fire-fighting system," state fire and emergency services minister Kaushik Chowdhury said.

CM Suvenud Adhikari said a five-member special investigation team (SIT) has been formed to probe the fire and alleged lapses in fire-safety measures. →P8



Fire service personnel at the site of the fire in Kolkata on Wednesday. SAMIR JANA/HT PHOTO

NO REGISTRATION FOR FOSSIL FUEL LCVs IN CORE NCR FROM JULY 2027

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NEW DELHI: No new CNG, diesel or petrol Light Goods Vehicle (LGV), with weight below 3,500 kg (N1 category) will be permitted to be registered in the national capital from January 1, 2027, and across the NCR districts of Gurugram, Faridabad, Sonapat, Ghaziabad and Gautam Buddha Nagar from July 1, 2027, the Commission for Air Quality Management said on Wednesday, calling for a phased transition towards electric goods vehicles.

MRNA VACCINE CUTS RECURRENCE OF MELANOMA IN CRUCIAL TRIAL

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NEW DELHI: Merck and Moderna announced on Wednesday morning that a bespoke mRNA cancer vaccine, given alongside Merck's blockbuster immunotherapy Keytruda after surgery, significantly reduced disease recurrence and metastasis in patients whose high-risk melanoma had just been surgically removed, compared to Keytruda alone. The news sent Moderna shares soaring 144% while Merck's stock climbed more than 11%. →P2

CAN'T ACCEPT NEED OF MP/MLA NOD TO GET ₹2.5K AID: HC

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NEW DELHI: The Delhi HC on Wednesday questioned Delhi government's decision to require Lakshmi Yojana beneficiaries to obtain an endorsement letter from an MP/MLA, as it said this could make access to the scheme dependent on a lawmaker's discretion.

JAIN SAYS ARREST 'POLITICAL', AHEAD OF PUNJAB POLLS

NEW DELHI: Former Delhi minister and AAP leader Satyendar Jain on Wednesday termed his arrest in a Delhi Jal Board (DJB)-related graft case as "politics", saying the arrest was linked to the upcoming Punjab elections. A Delhi court sent Jain and four accused to 14 days in judicial custody.

COLLECTORS IN 8 STATES, UTs TO TAKE CITIZENSHIP CALLS

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NEW DELHI: The Centre on Wednesday amended the citizenship rules to empower district collectors in six border states and two UTs to decide applications for Indian citizenship. →P6

Cars, ₹1L for upkeep to all legislators in TN

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CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu CM Vijay announced on Wednesday that every legislator will be given an official vehicle and ₹1 lakh in monthly allowance for fuel, maintenance and driver expenses, saying that the number of first-time MLAs who don't own vehicles has significantly increased. Speaker JCD Prabhakar said the scheme has been announced for all MLAs. The opposition DMK criticised the move, saying MLAs who own vehicles should be excluded from the scheme. →P5

TN pulls back order barring students from protests

CHENNAI: The Tamil Nadu government on Wednesday withdrew a controversial circular directing that students be prevented from participating in protests of Leftist groups and parties, including the Cockerroach Janta Party (CJP), after it sparked a row. →P5

{ SRI LANKA SERIES }

Fillip for India's test championship hopes after commanding Galle win

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KOLKATA: Manav Suthar took 10 wickets as India beat Sri Lanka by 165 runs in Galle on Wednesday, pocketing 12 crucial World Test Championship points to stay in the race for next year's final.

The win pushed India's points percentage from 48.14% to 53.33%. They, however, remain fifth in the WTC standings, behind Australia (77.77%), South Africa (75.00%), New Zealand (72.22%) and Bangla-



Manav Suthar took 10 wickets.

desh (66.67%). If India win their eight remaining Tests in the cycle, their points percentage could hit 74.07%, putting them in a strong position for the final. →P14

INDIA DEFEAT PAK 5-3, QUALIFY FOR SECOND ROUND IN HOCKEY WC

Skipper Harmanpreet Singh and striker Abhishek scored a brace each as India extended their decade-long unbeaten run over arch-rivals Pakistan with a 5-3 win in a high-voltage FIH World Cup Pool D match in Amstelveen, Netherlands on Wednesday to advance to the second round of the tournament. The defeat ended Pakistan's campaign in the tournament. →P13

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{ BUSINESS } FUNDS DIVERSION

CBI books Gensol, BluSmart founders



The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has registered a case against Gensol Engineering (GEL), its promoters and founders of ride-hailing service BluSmart Anmol Singh Jaggi and Puneet Singh Jaggi, and others for alleged misutilisation and diversion of funds borrowed from the Indian Renewable Energy Development Agency (IREDA). The FIR, filed on July 31, also names sister concern Gensol EV Lease Ltd and unidentified persons. The CBI case follows findings by the Sebi and IREDA concerning alleged diversion of funds raised for the purchase of electric vehicles. The Enforcement Directorate (ED) is conducting a parallel money-laundering probe against the Jaggis. →P12

{ SPORT } 'HUGE MISTAKE'

Kyrgios fails cocaine test, gets suspended



Former Wimbledon finalist Nick Kyrgios was provisionally suspended from tennis on Wednesday after testing positive for cocaine, with the volatile Australian owning up to his "huge mistake" in a public apology. The International Tennis Integrity Agency (ITIA) announced the suspension of the 31-year-old following a positive test for a cocaine metabolite, benzoylecgonine, from a sample taken during an ATP 250 event in Mallorca in June. "I made a huge mistake and I take full responsibility for it," Kyrgios said on Instagram. →P12

{ WORLD } CRIMINAL PROBE ORDERED

Israeli military admits firing on car in death of Hind Rajab



The Israeli military on Wednesday admitted its troops fired on a car carrying five-year-old Hind Rajab in Gaza in 2024, saying it had ordered a criminal investigation into the killing which drew international outrage. Hind Rajab's body was recovered from a car riddled with bullets in Gaza City days after she was last heard from in a desperate, hours-long phone call to the Palestinian Red Crescent on January 29, 2024. The Israeli military had previously denied its troops were present in the area near the incident. The military said it was launching a criminal probe into the 2025 killings of 15 Palestinians, including humanitarian personnel. →P17

{ MY INDIA } BHAGWANPURIA GANG

Indian added to FBI wanted criminal list



The FBI is on the lookout for Major Singh, an Indian national allegedly involved in narcotics and illegal arms smuggling, and has placed him on the list of "wanted" criminals. Singh is linked to the Jaggu Bhagwanpuria organised crime group, which originated in Punjab, and operated in California and elsewhere, FBI said. "Major Singh is wanted for his alleged involvement in a transnational criminal organisation engaged in racketeer influenced and corrupt organisations conspiracy..." the agency said in a statement on Tuesday. PTI

{ WORLD } FRANK BEARD

Boogie-rock trio ZZ Top's drummer dies



Frank Beard, the drummer for the Texas boogie-rock trio ZZ Top who kept the tempo for the band's biggest hits like "Sharp Dressed Man," "Gimme All Your Lovin'" and "Legs," has died. He was 77. Beard was in hospice care when he died Tuesday at his ranch in Richmond, Texas, according to publicist Bob Merlis. Band co-founder and guitarist Billy Gibbons, on tour with bassist Elwood Francis, hailed Beard in a statement. ZZ Top sold more than 50 million records and had six singles that reached No. 1 on Billboard's Mainstream Rock Airplay chart. Seven of their albums have been in the Billboard 200's Top 10 and they earned three Grammy Award nominations. AP

MRNA jab cuts recurrence of melanoma in landmark trial

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NEW DELHI: Merck and Moderna announced on Wednesday morning that a bespoke mRNA cancer vaccine, given alongside Merck's blockbuster immunotherapy Keytruda after surgery, significantly reduced disease recurrence and metastasis in patients whose high-risk melanoma had just been surgically removed, compared to Keytruda alone.

The Phase 3 INTERpath-001 trial enrolled 1,137 patients across stages IIB to IV and hit both its primary endpoint on recurrence-free survival and its secondary milestone on distant metastasis at a pre-specified interim analysis. The companies have not yet released the hazard ratios — the statistical measure of how successful the vaccine has been — pending presentation at a medical meeting, but the decision to halt the trial for efficacy at interim analysis signals a breakthrough.

The news sent Moderna shares soaring 144% to \$153.69 while Merck's stock climbed more than 11% to \$150.19. In plain terms, this is the sort of landmark that cancer research has been chasing for three decades in general, and the mRNA platform since its blockbuster Covid-19 success in 2020.

Three firsts

One: It is the first Phase 3 win



Moderna's share prices surged nearly 144% in the US stock market, at the time of going to print. Merck's stock climbed more than 11% →P12

— Phase 3 being the largest and most rigorous stage of drug testing, in which a candidate goes head-to-head against the standard of care — for an individualised neoantigen therapy, a class of medicine in which each patient receives a treatment manufactured specifically for their own tumour. The concept has been argued about in immunology journals since the mid-1990s; it has taken until now to produce a randomised trial that beats a standard of care.

Two, it is the first regimen to demonstrably improve on Keytruda alone in the adjuvant setting — adjuvant meaning treatment given after surgery to mop up residual disease before it becomes clinically visible. Since 2019, a queue of experimental combinations — LAG-3 inhibitors, TIGIT blockers, oncolytic viruses — have

tried to add benefit on top of Keytruda and failed.

Three, and most crucially: this is the proof the mRNA field had been waiting for. The Covid-19 vaccines established that mRNA could be manufactured at planetary scale and safely instruct human cells to produce a target protein on demand. What those vaccines did not settle was whether the platform could do anything therapeutically important beyond infectious disease. That question has hung over the sector for five years, dragging Moderna's revenues down as pandemic demand receded. INTERpath-001 is the first Phase 3 study to answer it in the affirmative.

Why cancer vaccines had been a graveyard

Almost every previous cancer vaccine has failed. Melacine, GVAX, Stimuvax, rindopepimut — each generation from the 1990s onward tried to teach the immune system to attack tumours and each hit the same wall at Phase 3. The vaccines were made off the shelf, targeting proteins over-expressed on cancer cells but also present on healthy tissue. Either the immune system refused to attack because it recognised the target as self, or it attacked and caused autoimmune disease.

The individualised neoantigen approach negates that trade-off. Cancer cells accumu-

late mutations that produce abnormal proteins; the fragments those proteins are chopped into and displayed on the tumour surface are called neoantigens — molecular mugshots unique to that tumour and absent from healthy tissue. Intismeran autogene is a strand of synthetic messenger RNA that codes for up to 34 of a patient's own tumour neoantigens.

Why this jab may be different

Once injected, the mRNA functions as instructions the body's own cells read and translate into those proteins, which are then displayed to the immune system to recognise. The Keytruda given alongside is a checkpoint inhibitor: it blocks a molecular handshake cancer cells use to signal "friend, not foe" and switch off attacking T-cells.

Keytruda's arrival in clinical practice a decade ago was most publicly demonstrated when it drove former US president Jimmy Carter's metastatic melanoma, which had spread to his brain and liver, into full remission in December 2015.

The two mechanisms are complementary: the vaccine teaches the immune system what a tumour looks like; the checkpoint inhibitor stops the tumour from silencing the T-cells that have learned to recognise it.

China shows off robotics might

The 2026 World Robot Conference opened in Beijing on Wednesday, with Chinese giants showing off their innovations — amid doubts over their readiness for work.

THE SHOW

The five-day event features over 300 companies, 2,000 exhibits and 150-plus product launches, according to Beijing authorities. To be sure, no other countries were exhibiting, despite the "World" in the conference's name.

WHAT THEY SHOWED

Unitree robots boxed, danced and played ping-pong against a human.

UBTECH's emotional-care humanoid — priced at \$24,000 — talks, makes facial expressions, moves its neck and hands, said deputy president Jiao Jichao.

Leju's robots sort crates in European and domestic auto plants, matching human efficiency, said assistant vice-president Zhang Dapeng.

Robotera's wheeled parcel-sorting torso runs 900–1,000 hours continuously at 85% of human effectiveness, a sales representative told Reuters.

DexForce robots packaged phones into boxes.

A helper robot at one booth tried for several minutes to fold a shirt. It failed.

IN WAKE OF U.S. BAN

The event follows a US ban, announced weeks earlier, on imports of new foreign-made humanoid and quadruped robots and power inverters, citing cybersecurity and national security risks — a move aimed at China.

UNITREE STOCK SURGES

Shares in Unitree surged 460% in their Shanghai trading debut after the company raised 6.1 billion yuan (\$904 million) in an IPO that will make it the first publicly traded humanoid robot maker in mainland China. The closing price gave Unitree a market value of 342 billion yuan.



Birth certificate pending: MCD seeks founding date

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NEW DELHI: The Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation marks September 4 as its foundation day, commemorating the first democratic general body meeting of the civic body in 1873. The Kolkata Municipal Corporation traces its origins even further back, to September 4, 1726, when a Royal Charter issued by King George I established the city's first civic governing body and Mayor's Court. But Delhi's municipal body, the agency that certifies births and deaths in the Capital, however, cannot quite settle on a birthday.

Its history offers not one, but several plausible dates — February 1863, June 1, 1863, April 7, 1958 and, arguably, one as late as 2022. The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has, at different points, chosen two of these dates to mark its institutional beginnings.

This year, it did not celebrate either.

The latest attempt came in the budget presented by the MCD standing committee, its most powerful panel, on January 28. It declared April 7 as the "MCD Foundation Day", arguing that the corporation in its present form came into existence in 1958, when Parliament brought together 13 separate local bodies and boards under one municipal institution.

The budget said the day would be marked every year with awards for excellence in cleanliness, education, gardens and health. Schools, villages, colonies, parks, hospitals and health centres were to be recognised for their performance.

But April 7 came and went without a foundation-day celebration. "Our intent is clear, MCD should have a foundation day and we should celebrate its history. We will clear the confusion and observe one day from next year," said Satya Sharma, chairperson of the standing committee.

The many colliding claims

The uncertainty is rooted in a deceptively simple question: when did Delhi's municipal government actually begin?

Archival records accessed by HT suggest that the answer could take the city back more than 160 years, to a time when Delhi's municipal administration was scattered.

A senior MCD official said that until 1957, municipal government in Delhi functioned under the Punjab District Boards Act, 1883 and the Punjab Municipal Act, 1911.

There were 13 separate bodies, each administering a particular area or performing a specific function. They included the Municipal Committee, Delhi; Notified Area Committee, Civil Station; Notified Area Committee, Red Fort; Municipal Committee, Delhi-Shahdara; Municipal Committee, West Delhi; Municipal Committee, South Delhi; Notified Area Committee, Mehrauli; Notified Area Committee, Najafgarh; Notified Area Committee, Narela; District Board, Delhi; Delhi State Electricity Board; Delhi Road Transport Authority; and the Delhi Joint Water and Sewage Board.

"There was no unified municipal body. The need to have a unified body to administer

MCD's 'birthday' options

FEBRUARY 1863

Archival documents show that a rudimentary form of a unified municipality in Delhi first came into being in February 1863, according to Rai Sahib Madho Pershad's 1921 history of Delhi's municipality. This is the earliest documented claim for the beginning of formal municipal governance in Delhi.

JUNE 1, 1863

The first general committee meeting of Delhi's municipality was held on June 1, 1863, under Commissioner Colonel GW Hamilton. The committee had 19 members — 12 British and seven Indian. The MCD House recognised this date in 2023, and resolution to observe June 1 as "Municipal Day" or "Nagar Nigam Diwas".



APRIL 7, 1958

This date is backed by the MCD standing committee. Parliament's 1957 Delhi Municipal Corporation Act brought 13 separate local bodies and boards under one unified MCD. The standing committee declared April 7 as MCD Foundation Day in its 2026 budget — but it has not been marked by any celebration yet.

MAY 22, 2022

The final date the three municipal corporations were reunited into a single MCD after a decade-long trifurcation.



(Right) The Chandni Chowk clock tower was also built by the committee in its initial years. Clock tower completed in 1870 at cost of ₹22,134

municipal affairs was being felt strongly, and thus a unified MCD was set up by an Act of Parliament in 1958," the official said.

That is the basis for the April 7 date. But it is only one chapter of the story.

In November 2023, the MCD House had already passed a resolution to observe June 1 as "Municipal Day" or "Nagar Nigam Diwas". The proposal, moved by the civic body's Heritage Cell, sought to commemorate the "beginning of formal

civic governance in the national Capital".

That date too has a historical claim.

The first general committee meeting of Delhi's municipality was held on June 1, 1863, with Colonel GW Hamilton, the commissioner, in the chair. The committee comprised 12 British and seven Indian members. Among the Indian members were wealthy and influential traders such as Lala Chhunna Mal, Lala Mahesh Das and Dewan Inamullah Khan.

But even June 1 may not be the precise beginning.

Rai Sahib Madho Pershad, an honorary magistrate who compiled a history of Delhi's municipality in 1921, wrote that "the municipality came into being in February 1863". On April 23 that year, he said, a kind of constituent assembly met under deputy commissioner FH Cooper to frame by-laws that would supplement Section 34 of the Police Act of 1861.

Then came the June 1 meeting of the general committee.

In simpler terms, February marks the birth of the institution, April marks the drafting of its rules, while June marks the first formal meeting of its general committee.

Teething troubles

For the city's earliest municipal administrators, however, the task was less about commemorating anniversaries and more about keeping Delhi functioning.

Pershad's account describes a municipality that immediately

turned its attention to roads, drains and sanitation. Roads were renewed, kutcha roads repaired, and drains and sewers cleared — some of which, he wrote, had not been cleaned for nearly 20 years.

To be sure, the municipality's jurisdiction was tiny by what we understand MCD to be today. In 1863, it covered just around five square kilometres and served a population of around 121,000. Today, MCD covers more than 1,400 sq km and serves a population estimated at over 20 million.

The fledgling administration also introduced some of the foundations of modern civic governance: a sanitation and conservancy system was established, a Unani dispensary opened in Sadar Bazar, and registration of births and deaths began. In subsequent years came firefighting arrangements, water supply systems and municipal taxation.

One problem, however, appears to have survived almost unchanged: money.

Archives show that the municipality's income from January to December 1863 was ₹98,276. Its ambitions were considerably larger. Improving the channel of the Yamuna, constructing a general hospital and setting up a vegetable market were among the projects under consideration. "But the committee's efforts were limited for want of funds and the fact that they had to pay no less than 50% of their income towards the cost of the city police alone," Pershad's memoir adds.

Over the decades, Delhi's municipal structure continued to evolve, repeatedly changing its size, powers and administrative boundaries.

Deep Chand Mathur, who

worked as the MCD director of information between 1980 and 2011, said that there have been five major changes in the number of elected municipal representatives so far. "The civic body had just 80 councillors till 1963. But then, a major decentralisation exercise was taken up with a number of powers were delegated to zonal committees and the number of councillors was raised to 100 in 1967. The number did not change for another 26 years, and then it was raised to 134 in 1993," he said.

"Between 1993 and 2002, MCD elections were fought over 134 seats. In 2007, the number of wards was increased to 272. Later in 2022, while the Centre reunited the three separate corporations, the number of wards was reduced to 250," Mathur said.

And that brings the city to the latest claim for the birthday.

If April 7, 1958 is considered the MCD's foundation because it brought disparate civic bodies under one corporation, what about May 22, 2022 — the day the three corporations (North MCD, South MCD and East MCD) created after the 2012 trifurcation were reunited into a single MCD?

The question goes beyond calendars and ceremonial events. It is about what constitutes the birth of a civic institution. Is an institution established when its first organisational structure begins to emerge, when its first formal committee meets, when legislation creates a unified body, or when an existing institution is fundamentally reconstituted?

MCD officials did not respond to requests for comment.

Delhi's answer appears to be: all of the above, depending on which chapter of its history one chooses to focus on.

MY BENGALURU

Anti-poaching camps in Chamrajanagar blown up

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MYSURU/BENGALURU: Unidentified miscreants allegedly blew up several anti-poaching camps in the Cauvery Wildlife Sanctuary in Chamrajanagar using explosives, officials from the forest department said on Wednesday.

The attacks come amid continuing anger against the forest department following the killing of three alleged poachers in an exchange of fire on August 15. The Minchinarehalla anti-poaching camp in the Kothanur zone was reportedly destroyed using dynamite and gelatin sticks. The intensity of the blast damaged the camp walls and burnt materials kept inside, sources added.

Several other anti-poaching camps in the Kothanur zone – Minchinahalli, Bheemeshwari, Ollemarada Hatti, Budikere, Bandahalli and Kalidoddi were also targeted in the intervening night of August 18-19.

There were no injuries reported.

Reacting to the developments, Karnataka chief minister D K Shivakumar said the government would wait for the outcome of the inquiry into the August 15 killing of the three alleged poachers before commenting on the matter.

"We are not going to speak about it now. They (forest officials) are giving various pieces

SEVERAL OTHER ANTI-POACHING CAMPS IN THE KOTHANUR ZONE -- MINCHINAHALLI, BHEEMESHWARI, OLLEMARADA HATTI, BUDIKERE, BANDAHALLI AND KALIDODDI WERE ALSO TARGETED

of information, but an investigation is underway. We are going very deep into the matter. Let the report come after the investigation, and then I will speak about it," Shivakumar told reporters in Bengaluru.

"Our forest minister is also already conducting a very detailed inquiry into the matter," he added.

The three deceased men -- Anthony Samy, John Rose Peter and Kumar, residents of villages in Hanur taluk of Chamrajanagar district, were shot dead by forest department personnel in the early hours of August 15 in the Cauvery Wildlife Sanctuary area.

According to Karnataka authorities, forest personnel conducting an anti-poaching operation after receiving information about suspected wildlife poaching came under fire from the group, following which the personnel allegedly fired in self-

defence. The three men were killed in the exchange of fire.

The issue has echoed in neighbouring Tamil Nadu, with political parties claiming the victims were Tamils and had questioned the Karnataka officials' explanation over the firing incident.

Following the incident, Tamil Nadu CM C Joseph Vijay strongly condemned the alleged killings and said the explanation given by the Karnataka Forest Department regarding the incident is unacceptable.

A fair investigation should be conducted by a high-level committee on the heinous incident, he had said in a social media post late on Sunday.

The issue also came up in the Tamil Nadu Assembly on Tuesday, with members moving a call attention motion demanding a high-level probe into the forest department firing incident.

Additional Conservator of Forests (ACF) Mariswamy said there are 28 camps in the Cauvery Wildlife Sanctuary and eight camps have been destroyed. Police security has also been provided to the forest.

"Farmers have not committed this act, poachers have done this. If anti-poaching camps are damaged, it will be difficult to prevent human-wildlife conflict," the ACF appealed. As a precautionary measure, police said that security has been provided.

Govt to constitute SIT to probe fake medicine network: Min

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BENGALURU: The Karnataka government has decided to constitute a special investigation team (SIT) to probe the suspected network involved in manufacturing and distributing counterfeit medicines and branded pharmaceutical products, health minister U T Khader said on Wednesday.

The decision comes after authorities uncovered a suspected fake medicine manufacturing and packaging unit at a farmhouse near C K Thandya village, close to Dodderi in Bengaluru South district.

Officials found a setup allegedly used for manufacturing, packaging and labelling medicines using the names of reputed multinational pharmaceutical companies.

Bottles were reportedly being labelled, capped and prepared for distribution in the market. Some expired products were also found during the inspection, raising concerns over possible health risks.

"Fake branded medicines

and cosmetics are being manufactured and supplied through a network. We have decided to constitute an SIT to investigate the entire network and identify the people and organisations involved," Khader said.

He said the authorities were particularly concerned over the alleged manufacture of counterfeit injections, including medicines used in intensive care units.

"Medicines from other states and countries were allegedly brought here and labels of multinational companies were put on them before they were sold. Even ICU medicines have been counterfeited. We need to find out which hospitals and medical stores received these products and whether patients were affected," he said.

The farmhouse belongs to a person identified as Siddaiah and had reportedly been leased to Prashanth, who is currently believed to be in Dubai. Police have detained a person identified as Prabhudev in connection with the case.

Khader said the investigation indicated that the sus-



U T Khader

pected network could extend beyond Karnataka, with links being examined in states including Himachal Pradesh and Telangana.

"We will examine the entire chain, including the source of the medicines, the distribution network and the hospitals to which they may have reached. The SIT will help us investigate the matter comprehensively," he said.

SP Srinivas Gowda gave more details about the operation carried out on Tuesday night.

We received information about suspicious movement of

vehicles and boxes being loaded at a farmhouse near Dodderi village. Our beat staff Shivraju and Raghu alerted us, following which our team conducted a raid and uncovered the suspected fake medicine racket," South district superintendent of police Srinivas Gowda said.

"During the inspection, we found medicines suspected to be counterfeit and immediately informed the drug control department. Police and drug control officials jointly inspected the premises and confirmed the presence of counterfeit medicines," he said.

"Our investigation indicates that high-end medicines used in intensive care units were being targeted. The accused allegedly procured medicines at lower prices, replaced the original packaging and labels with those of foreign pharmaceutical companies and supplied them to the market. We are investigating where these medicines were supplied and how extensive the network is," Gowda said.

"One person has been

arrested and two others are being questioned. We are also investigating whether more people are involved in the racket and identifying the locations where the medicines were supplied," he said.

"The prime accused, Prashanth, is currently abroad. We are making efforts to secure his arrest at the earliest. The case has been registered based on a complaint from the drug control department and the investigation is continuing," Gowda said.

"The farmhouse, spread over around 10 acres, was reportedly leased by Prashanth for agricultural purposes at an annual rent of about ₹10 lakh. We are examining whether the premises were used for manufacturing and repackaging the counterfeit medicines," he added. Earlier, the Drug Enforcement Wing of the FDA has seized spurious and expired drugs worth over ₹4.91 crore during an inspection drive that allegedly uncovered an unlicensed pharmaceutical repacking and relabelling operation, officials said on Wednesday.

Techie seeks approver status in KR Puram triple murder case

Coovercolly Indresh

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BENGALURU: The KR Puram triple murder investigation has taken a fresh turn with accused Shwetha Somasundar, a techie, approaching the 29th Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate (ACJM) court to file a confession statement, officials said on Wednesday. She claimed that she was present when the killings took place but did not directly participate in the murders, and has alleged that co-accused Kenneth carried out the attacks.

The case relates to the deaths of 48-year-old Muthulakshmi S, her 54-year-old husband Somasundar and their 20-year-old younger daughter Supriya. The three were found dead at their residence in Sai Green Apartment in Seegehalli, within the KR Puram police station limits, on June 22, 2026.

Shwetha told the court that she did not intend to kill anyone and that she is willing to disclose information about the incident. However, the 29th ACJM court has indicated that her application can be considered after the police complete the investigation and file the chargesheet.

Investigators suspect that Kenneth was responsible for the fatal attacks and that Shwetha was present at the scene. Her request to become an approver is significant as she is now offering to provide evidence against

THE ACCUSED CLAIMED THAT SHE WAS PRESENT WHEN THE KILLINGS TOOK PLACE BUT DID NOT DIRECTLY PARTICIPATE IN THE MURDERS

her co-accused. Police are examining a possible financial motive behind the crime. Investigators have reportedly found that debts running into tens of lakhs of rupees, with estimates ranging from around ₹30 lakh to ₹56 lakh, had created financial pressure.

Shwetha's family members had allegedly questioned her over the loans and repayment.

The investigation has also focused on allegations that Kenneth and Shwetha used an artificial intelligence chatbot while planning the crime.

The suspects allegedly fled after the murders and travelled through parts of Karnataka and Tamil Nadu. Confirming the development KR Puram police inspector and IO B Rama Murthy told HT that "She expressed willingness to become an approver, but court said it will consider her plea after the charge sheet is submitted" he added. Police said the investigation to determine

ENCROACHMENTS IN B'LURU TO BE CLEARED BY AUG END: MINISTER

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BENGALURU: With 964 km of footpath encroachments already cleared across the GBA area, Minister Krishna Byre Gowda on Wednesday directed officials to clear the remaining ones by the end of August.

Addressing a virtual meeting held to review the ongoing drives to clear footpath encroachments, implement the 'Freedom from Waste' campaign and remove abandoned vehicles across the Greater Bengaluru Authority (GBA) area, the minister said encroachment clearance is being undertaken along nearly 1,500 km of arterial and sub-arterial roads in the city.

Of this, encroachments along 964 km of footpaths has already been cleared.

Officials were directed to complete the clearance of all remaining ones by the end of this month.

In a statement, the GBA said that the minister instructed officials to carry out the footpath clearance drive strictly according to the planned schedule and directed that repairs of footpaths at locations where encroachments have been removed should be taken up simultaneously.

"It has been observed that street vendors are returning to locations from which footpath encroachments have already been removed and resuming business," it said.

MUDA row: Govt cancels nearly 1,100 sites under 50:50 schemes over rule violation

Coovercolly Indresh

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BENGALURU: The state government has ordered the cancellation of around 1,100 alternative sites allotted under the controversial 50:50 scheme by the Mysuru Urban Development Authority (MUDA) in violation of its March 14, 2023 directive, urban development minister Dr Yathindra Siddaramaiah said on Wednesday.

The decision follows recommendations of the single-member inquiry commission and a report submitted by a high-level technical committee examining irregularities in 50:50 site allotments. The order will come into

OFFICIALS HAVE BEEN ASKED TO SUBMIT COMPLIANCE REPORTS TO THE GOVERNMENT ON THE ACTION TAKEN UNDER THE ORDER

effect immediately, the minister said. The government has directed the MUDA chairman and Mysuru deputy commissioner, MUDA commissioner and concerned local authorities to cancel all allotment orders issued in violation of the March 14, 2023 government directive.

The government has also ordered authorities to initiate civil proceedings to cancel sale deeds of such alternative sites that have already been registered at sub-registrar offices.

In cases where sale deeds have not yet been executed, MUDA has been directed not to issue any new sale deeds until the government frames clear guidelines and issues further instructions. The government has further directed the Mysuru City Corporation, concerned municipal councils and gram panchayats to put on hold the khata process for sites that have already been registered.

Where khatahs have already been issued, local bodies have

been instructed to examine their cancellation under the Karnataka Municipal Corporations Act, 1976, Karnataka Municipalities Act, 1961 and Karnataka Gram Swaraj and Panchayat Raj Act, 1993, as applicable.

Officials have been asked to submit compliance reports to the government on the action taken under the order.

The government has warned that failure to implement the directions could invite disciplinary action against the officials concerned.

According to the minister, the approximately 1,100 sites being cancelled in the first phase are estimated to have a combined value of around Rs 2,000 crore.

MIN ORDERS SWIFT RENOVATION OF TOURISM PLACES

Press Trust of India

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BENGALURU: Karnataka tourism minister K J George on Wednesday directed officials to take immediate steps for the comprehensive development and renovation of major tourism and cultural attractions in the heart of Bengaluru.

These include Bal Bhavan, KSTDC Mayura Hotel, Bengaluru Government Museum and Venkatappa Art Gallery. The objective was to provide a better experience for families, the public and tourists, officials said. The minister made a surprise visit to the KSTDC Mayura Hotel and reviewed the hotel's facilities, cleanliness, food services.

Captain Abhimanyu turns 60



Captain Abhimanyu, the iconic elephant that carried the golden howdah during the Mysuru Dasara Jambhoosavari for six consecutive years, has retired after turning 60. Rural development minister Eshwar Khadare urged the government to allow Abhimanyu to participate in the procession once more and receive a ceremonial farewell.

HT PHOTO

Income limit for social security pension hiked

Press Trust of India

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BENGALURU: The Karnataka Revenue Department has issued an order to continue pensions for eligible beneficiaries under the Social Security Pension Scheme whose annual income, after verification, is between Rs 32,000 and Rs 1,20,000.

Deputy Chief Minister and Revenue Minister G Parameshwara said the decision resolves a long-pending demand of the people.

"For various social security pensions, including old-age pension, widow pension and disability pension, the annual income limit was Rs 32,000. This ceiling had remained unchanged for a

long time, and lakhs of people were excluded from pension benefits. By raising the annual income limit to Rs 1,20 lakh, we have addressed a long-standing issue," Parameshwara said.

According to the department, when data from the Family Database was matched with pension beneficiary records, 23,14,544 beneficiaries were flagged as 'doubtful cases'.

According to the department, when data from the Family Database was matched with pension beneficiary records, 23,14,544 beneficiaries were flagged as 'doubtful cases'. It was found during verification of the 23,14,544 doubtful cases that their annual income exceeded Rs 32,000.

BC Nagesh's last rites to be performed today

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BIDAR: Tributes poured in for senior BJP leader and former minister B C Nagesh, who died on Tuesday due to chronic health issues. He was 67-year-old. Members of the party, his supporters, and leaders of various political parties arrived to pay their last respects to Nagesh, who served as the former MLA of the Tiptur constituency and as the state's minister for primary and secondary education. The district administration informed that his last rites will be performed in Tiptur on Thursday with full state honours.

The Tumakuru district administration has made the necessary preparations for Nagesh's final rites. Deputy Commissioner Shubha Kalyan said that adequate security arrangements have been made to ensure no untoward incidents occur during the final viewing and funeral.

Thousands of people and dignitaries from various fields are expected to arrive to pay their last respects to the former minister. In view of this, the district administration has taken several measures to control the



CMDK Shivakumar pays last tributes to the mortal remains of former minister BC Nagesh in Bengaluru on Wednesday.

PTI

crowd, ensure smooth traffic movement, and provide necessary facilities to the public. Senior officials and police personnel have already been stationed in the area where the funeral will be held.

The deputy commissioner is personally inspecting the preparations for the final rites and has given necessary instructions to the concerned officials, he said, adding that the district administration has appealed to the public to maintain peace and order.

Supporters have been given an opportunity to pay their last respects at Nagesh's residence in Tiptur. Family members,

close associates, party workers, and supporters are arriving to pay their final tributes to the departed leader.

Nagesh's son Vishwadeep spoke to the media and provided information about the final rites. He said that, after discussions with family members and senior leaders, it had been decided to conduct the funeral on Thursday. He said that the exact location where the funeral will be held would be officially announced after consultations with family members and elders.

Several political leaders from across the state have expressed deep condolences over his

death. Former chief minister HD Kumaraswamy condoled his passing and remembered Nagesh as a popular leader with a simple and amicable personality. Kumaraswamy said that, as minister for primary education, he had carried out many good works and that his death was a great loss to the state.

State BJP President B Y Vijayendra expressed his condolence. "The news of the untimely demise of Shri B C Nagesh, a senior leader of the party, former MLA from the Tiptur constituency and former minister, has come as a profound shock and caused immense grief. With his passing, our party and the state have lost a gentlemanly public representative and an exemplary politician," Chief minister DK Shivakumar on Wednesday paid tribute to the former BJP minister.

In a post on X, Karnataka Shivakumar described former minister BC Nagesh as an honest individual who performed excellently during his tenure as the Education Minister.

Highlighting his administrative contributions, Shivakumar noted that Nagesh made significant efforts to bring discipline and structure to the state's education sector.

'He will not resign': Cong backs min Nagendra over fund fraud

Naheed Ataulla

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BENGALURU: The Congress government in Karnataka took a firm stand to back minister B Nagendra over his alleged involvement in the multi crore rupee embezzlement in the Karnataka Maharshi Valmiki Scheduled Tribes Development Corporation (KMVSTDC), stating that no court of law had convicted him, even as the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the Janata Dal (Secular-JDS) deadlock demanding the minister's dismissal continued for the third day on Wednesday.

The first indication that the Congress will not back down to the opposition's demand seeking the minister's resignation was given by chief minister DK Shivakumar late on Tuesday evening. After the Congress Legislature Party (CLP) meeting, Shivakumar said there was no question of seeking Nagendra's resignation. "Let the opposition parties give a notice to discuss the issue in the House. There are many Union ministers facing criminal cases by the Enforcement Directorate (ED)," he

B NAGENDRA WAS ALLEGEDLY INVOLVED IN THE MULTI CRORE EMBEZZLEMENT IN THE MAHARSHI VALMIKI SCHEDULED TRIBES DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION

maintained.

Even as the BJP-JD(S) staged dharna and shouted slogans in both Houses of the legislature, the government chose to go ahead with the business in the agenda.

Tabling a statement in the Assembly, deputy chief minister G Parameshwara said ₹5 crore was given back even before the funds misappropriation was detected. Of the ₹84.63 crore cash transferred illegally, money and valuables worth ₹79.68 crore have been recovered and the process to get the remaining amount is underway," he added.

"All of you are aware that the Supreme court and several other

courts have sharply criticised the ED and Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) functioning. Courts have observed that these agencies have lost their sanctity by acting as per the whims and fancies of the party in power (in Centre)," Parameshwara said. He also cited a recent affidavit filed before the Supreme Court which said 4,192 sitting and former elected representatives had pending criminal cases. They included 251 Lok Sabha and 75 Rajya Sabha members besides 14 CMs.

Not impressed by his reply, leader of opposition in the Assembly R Ashoka said: "This is not a washing machine to put powder and the taint against the minister will go. Instead of making this statement, get Nagendra to resign."

Before the Assembly met, Nagendra along with Kannada and culture minister Shivaraj S Tangadagi and chief minister's political secretary AS Ponnanna met the media. Alleging he was being targeted by the "Manuvidis" as he was a Dalit, the minister asked the opposition why the resignations of Union ministers was not being asked.

OVER 10.7 MILLION ELECTORS MARKED UNDER ASDDO DURING STATE S.I.R.

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: More than 10.7 million electors have been marked under the ASDDO category during the ongoing SIR of electoral rolls in Karnataka, officials said on Wednesday.

As on August 16, there were 5,54,32,314 electors in the electoral roll, and the same number of enumeration forms (EFs) were printed and distributed, officials said. The house-to-house enumeration and digitisation period was from June 30 to August 17, officials said.

According to a statement issued by the office of Karnataka chief electoral officer V Anbukumar, of the total EFs, 5,54,32,314 or 100 per cent were digitised. A total of 1,07,96,415 electors (19.48%) were marked as Absent, Shifted, Duplicate, Dead and Others (ASDDO). In Bangalore Urban district alone, out of 40,21,039 total electors -- over 1.717 million have been marked as ASDDO, in BBMP (North) it is over 1.052 million, in BBMP (Central), the data showed.

SOUTH REGION

HT

Tamil Nadu police set up internal vigilance cell

CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu Police has formed internal vigilance cells in all the districts and commissionerates to strengthen integrity, transparency and public confidence, officers said on Wednesday. Director general of police Mahesh Kumar Agarwal directed the officials to set up district wise internal vigilance cells along with provision to receive complaints over call or WhatsApp.

Kerala HC gives govt 6 weeks to fill Waqf Board

KOCHI: The Kerala High Court on Wednesday granted six weeks time to the state government to fill up the vacancies in the State Waqf Board.

A bench of Chief Justice Soumen Sen and Justice Syam Kumar V issued the direction while hearing several PILs, including one by BJP leader Shone George, alleging that the functioning of the Board was illegal as it did not have two non-Muslim members as mandated by the relevant Act.

Hyd museum to get facelift, says T'gana minister

HYDERABAD: Telangana tourism and archaeology minister Jupally Krishna Rao on Wednesday said the state government would take comprehensive steps to give a facelift to the Dr YSR State Heritage Museum. Rao, who inspected the museum on Wednesday, directed officials to take all necessary measures for the safe and scientific conservation of the exhibits, which include a 2,500-year-old Egyptian mummy.

Massive irregularities in Group-I exam during YSRCP govt: Naidu

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HYDERABAD: Andhra Pradesh chief minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Wednesday accused the previous YSR Congress Party (YSRCP) government of compromising with the integrity of the Andhra Pradesh Public Service Commission (APSC) Group-I job recruitment process.

Participating in a special discussion in the state assembly on alleged irregularities in the conduct of Group-I examinations during the previous government's tenure, Naidu said a court-directed probe by the special investigation team (SIT) had found that the APPSC had entrusted the evaluation of candidates' answer scripts to people who lacked the required qualifications, including electricians, drivers, plumbers and security guards.

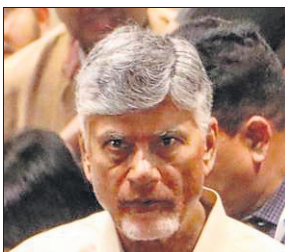
"The Group-I services is one of the state's most important civil services... Thousands of aspirants spend years preparing for Group-I examinations,"

Naidu said, adding that the 2018 Group-I notification had attracted around 114,000 applications, from which 325 candidates were shortlisted.

"Among those who evaluated the answer scripts were unemployed persons, homemakers, security guards, a flower decorator, a sales executive at a jewellery shop, a driver, an electrician, a hospital laboratory technician and a supervisor at Gandhi Park," Naidu claimed.

He alleged that 66 evaluators had examined examination papers without proper authorisation, while of the 72 people entrusted with evaluation from a larger panel, 25 were allegedly appointed without following the prescribed procedure.

Naidu noted that the high court had directed that manual evaluation be undertaken instead of digital evaluation, and alleged that answer scripts were initially evaluated in Hyderabad before being removed from the APPSC strong room without proper authorisation and subsequently stored for 84 days in a resort in Guntur



N Chandrababu Naidu

district.

He said work orders worth ₹1.19 crore were issued for the evaluation-related arrangements. He also alleged that the authorities continued with interviews and recruitment despite court proceedings concerning the evaluation process.

Naidu alleged that the previous administration also compromised the confidentiality of the evaluation process by transmitting PDF copies of answer scripts through private Gmail accounts, Google Drive and WhatsApp groups.

The chief minister claimed 49,000 duplicate OMR slips were printed at a private facility.

He alleged that forensic examination had detected alterations in the answer sheets. "Of 734 OMR slips examined, alterations were allegedly detected in 718, while 21 slips reportedly did not carry signatures," Naidu said.

He also referred to forensic science laboratory findings that allegedly indicated the use of whitener on OMR valuation slips, despite APPSC rules prohibiting its use. He also alleged that CCTV cameras were not installed in the answer-script evaluation hall for 17 days, while mobile phones were allegedly allowed inside the premises.

The chief minister said the high court subsequently examined the matter and appointed a three-member committee headed by a retired judge to look into the allegations.

Naidu said the government would examine the entire episode and take further action based on the SIT findings.

He said the government would consult the public, intellectuals and other stakeholders

to strengthen the recruitment and evaluation systems.

On April 25, 2025, a case was registered based on a complaint lodged by then APPSC secretary Rajababu, who alleged irregularities in the evaluation of the Group-I Mains exam papers. On May 7, P Madhusudan Rao, managing director of Camsigns Media Private Ltd, who was engaged by the APPSC for the evaluation of answer sheets; and former intelligence chief PS R Anjaneyulu, who was the APPSC chairman, were arrested. The SIT probing the case was formed in compliance with a court order on February 11.

Leader of Opposition in the legislative council Botsa Satyanarayana said YSRCP was ready to face a detailed CBI inquiry into the matter.

"But at the same time, we also want a detailed CBI probe into the alleged irregularities in the conduct of teachers' recruitment by the present coalition government under Mega DSC-2025 programme. Is the government ready?" he asked.

Vijay: All MLAs to be given cars, ₹1L allowance

S Vijay Karthik
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CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay announced on Wednesday that his government will provide every legislator in the state an official vehicle and a monthly ₹1-lakh allowance for fuel, maintenance and driver expenses, saying that the number of first-time MLAs who don't have their own vehicles has significantly increased. As many as 110 MLAs are first-timers.

He said the decision was made to help the MLAs take up constituency development work. Assembly Speaker JCD Prabhakar said the scheme has been announced for all MLAs.

The decision was welcomed by legislators across party lines, however, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), the main opposition in the Tamil Nadu assembly, criticised it, saying that MLAs who own vehicles should be excluded from the scheme.

In a suo motu response to Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) MLA LE Jothamani's request on August 12 for a vehicle—as he found it difficult to travel to the Secretariat every day—the CM said several MLAs don't own a personal vehicle, making it difficult for them to inspect and review constituency work.

"I am pleased to announce that vehicles will be provided by the government to all members of the legislative assembly," the CM said. "The government running an honest administration without bribery must fulfil the basic needs of its members," he added.

Vijay said a monthly allowance of ₹75,000 would be provided to cover expenses including driver salary, fuel, and vehicle maintenance. Additionally, ₹25,000 will be provided to appoint an assistant for office work.

"...necessary amendments will be made to the relevant Act and official orders will be issued," Vijay said. Salary, allowances and perks to legislators are regulated through a state-specific law.

Meanwhile, DMK spokesperson Saravanan Annadurai said, "The TVK government wants to splurge public money on luxury,



C Joseph Vijay

which is not a priority." "The CM said that the state coffers were wiped out when he took charge as the CM. Now, how will they fulfill this promise?" Annadurai asked.

Former DMK MLA and medical wing secretary Ezhilan said the government should provide vehicles only to those who do not own one. "Those MLAs who declared in the election affidavit that they own a vehicle should not be given a vehicle," he said.

Desiya Murpokku Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMDK) leader Premmalatha Vijayakant said that 90% of MLAs own vehicles and the annual expenditure due to this would be ₹150 crore.

"It is true that many newly elected TVK MLAs do not have their own vehicle. That is why he has invested ₹150 crore," she said. She further asked that if that much money can be spent for MLAs, why farmers' loans were not being waived.

The 234-member Tamil Nadu assembly has 227 MLAs with seven seats vacant due to the resignation of six All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) MLAs, who joined TVK, and from one seat CM Vijay had resigned. He had won from two different constituencies (Tiruchirappalli East and Perambur) and tendered resignation from Tiruchirappalli East.

In a parallel decision, the TVK government expanded its flagship Chief Minister's Comprehensive Health Insurance Scheme from the current ₹5 lakh to ₹25 lakh per year.

"The value of human life should never be determined by their income. Our government is firm in its stance that the divide between the privileged and the underprivileged should not exist in the health care sector," CM Vijay said. "Healthcare is not a privilege; it is the fundamental right of every human being," he said.

MLA under house arrest



A police officer restrains former minister and BRS MLA T Harish Rao outside his residence in Kokapet. In a post on X, Harish claimed he was placed under house arrest while heading to visit TIMS Hospital in Hyderabad's Sanathnagar on Wednesday.

ANI

Lokesh addresses fears over AI data centres' power, water usage

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HYDERABAD: Andhra Pradesh information technology minister Nara Lokesh on Wednesday addressed apprehensions that the upcoming data centres in Visakhapatnam would be environmentally hazardous and would require huge power and water supply.

Responding to a question raised by Jana Sena MLA Lokam Naga Madhavi in the assembly, the minister alleged that deliberate misinformation was being spread over their environmental and water requirements for the data centres.

He added data centres are critical to the AI-driven digital economy and India's data sovereignty, particularly amid emerging geopolitical challenges.

He explained that once the



Nara Lokesh

proposed data-centre ecosystem reaches the targeted 6.5 GW capacity, it is estimated to require around 3 TMC (thousand million cubic feet) of water annually based on current technology, while stressing that newer cooling technologies are expected to reduce water consumption further.

He said water for data centres would come from the industrial allocation of Polavaram water, without diverting water meant

for the city's residents. He said the government was committed to supplying Visakhapatnam's urban water requirements through Polavaram, with gravity-based supply expected within 18 months. "Dedicated pipelines would be provided for data centres," he added.

Comparing water consumption, Lokesh said a 1 GW thermal power plant consumes nearly 10 times more water annually than a data centre, questioning why protests over water usage were focused only on data centres.

The IT minister said chief minister N Chandrababu Naidu had set a clear ceiling of 6.5 GW for data-centre allocations, and declared that the target has now been fully achieved. "The government would prioritise companies that demonstrate strong environmental responsibility," he added.

2 minors held for killing school principal in Nalgonda: Police

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HYDERABAD: Two minors enrolled in a school in Nalgonda district whose 48-year-old principal was found murdered on August 12 were detained in connection with the case on Wednesday, said police, adding that they were suspected to have committed the murder as part of a planned robbery.

Addressing a press conference, district SP Sarath Chandra Pawar said since both accused would be produced before the Juvenile Justice Board.

Kallu Roopa Reddy, principal and director of Nagarjuna Grammar English Medium School in Kondamallepally, was found dead with at least 27 stab injuries on her body at her home at JB Colony of Kondamallepally mandal headquarters. Both her husband Kallu Rajender Reddy and son Abhinav Reddy were away in Hyderabad when the murder took place on the night of August 11, said police.

According to Pawar, the two Class 10 students allegedly



Kallu Roopa Rai

planned the robbery nearly five days in advance, believing that Roopa Reddy would have a substantial amount of cash at home as school fee collections were underway. "Investigations revealed that one of the accused entered the house by jumping over the compound wall while wearing a mask. However, the mask reportedly came off, allowing Roopa Reddy to recognise him. Fearing that he would be identified, the student allegedly attacked her with a knife," the SP said. The accused also took away her mobile phone before fleeing from the scene, along with cash from her bag.

As part of the investigation, the police examined the video footage obtained from around 70 CCTV cameras installed in

and around the locality.

"The school remained closed for four days following the murder. After it reopened, police made inquiries about 13 students who were absent... Further probe revealed that two absentee students had suddenly been spending money lavishly for two or three days," he said.

The police took the two students into custody and questioned them and found ₹1.54 lakh in cash and the victim's phone with one of them. "The student initially claimed that the money had been given to him by his parents. However, police noticed bloodstains on the currency notes. Samples were sent to a laboratory and were found to be human blood," the SP said.

The probe revealed that the student who had stabbed the principal had previously been staying in the school hostel. "A few days ago, the principal found some cash and a mobile phone in his bag. She reprimanded him in the presence of his parents and subsequently shifted him from the hostel to day-scholar status," the SP said.

THREE-DAY RSS ALL-INDIA MEETING BEGINS IN VIZAG

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HYDERABAD: The three-day Akhil Bharatiya Samanvay Baithak of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) began at Gurulova near Visakhapatnam in Andhra Pradesh on Wednesday, an RSS functionary said.

The meeting was inaugurated by RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat and secretary Dattatreya Hosabale. "The meeting will continue until the evening of August 21," the functionary said.

The meeting was attended by all the other RSS office bearers, besides national presidents, general secretaries, all-India organization heads and some selected workers from 32 diverse organizations inspired by the Sangh.

RSS Akhil Bharatiya Prachar Pramukh Sunil Ambekar told reporters that the meeting was aimed at sharing experiences and strengthening coordination among organisations inspired by the Sangh.

Will fight allegations legally and politically: Riyas after ED raids

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: CPI(M) MLA and former Kerala public works minister PA Mohammed Riyas on Wednesday said that he would fight the Directorate of Enforcement (ED)'s actions legally and politically, a day after the agency raided premises linked to his close associates in Kozhikode.

The raids were carried out in eight locations across Kozhikode district, including at a building owned by CPM district secretariat member P Nikhil and a house linked to a close friend of the Beypore MLA. They were part of the ED probe under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) in the CMRL - Exalogic case. The case pertains to allegedly suspicious transactions between CMRL, a chemicals manufacturer, and Exalogic, a now-defunct IT firm, run by Veena T, who is Riyas's wife and former CM



PA Mohammed Riyas

Pinarayi Vijayan's daughter.

"I will fight any allegations against me legally and politically. Some of my friends, whom I have known since college and others through my political work, were questioned yesterday for hours. They run their businesses conforming with all rules of the land. They are well-known and respectable people. Despite (the raids), my ties with them will remain intact," he told reporters, in his first public interaction addressing the case.

"Everyone knows how the BJP government at the Centre has misused agencies like ED.

We know that the ED is very selective about the cases it handles and others that it declines to probe," he said.

"We are not like those who get elected on the 'hand' symbol and join the BJP later. We will not run away. We are not scared," he said.

Meanwhile, ED on Wednesday claimed it seized some "hand written" notes during searches against Veena T in May and these contained details of certain fund transfers to Dubai. The agency claimed that digital devices seized from her during these raids contained a photo of a SIM card obtained in the name of some other person, allegedly used by her to make Internet-based calls. It added that its raids on August 18 were against those who were named in Veena's hand written accounts and the person who allegedly gave her the SIM card.

(with PTI inputs)



Amit Shah

SHAH TO CHAIR 31ST MEETING OF SOUTHERN ZONAL COUNCIL TODAY

S Vijay Karthik
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CHENNAI: Union home minister Amit Shah is scheduled to chair the 31st meeting of the Southern Zonal Council at a hotel in Mahabalipuram on Thursday, the Centre said in a statement on Wednesday.

The Southern Zone council comprises Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Kerala, Tamil Nadu and Telangana and Puducherry, Andaman and Nicobar Islands and Lakshadweep.

The meeting is being organised by the Inter-State Council secretariat and Union ministry of home affairs, while the Tamil Nadu government is the host, said the statement.

Amit Shah serves as the council's chairman while Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay is the current vice chairman.

Under Sections 15 to 22 of the States Reorganisation Act, 1956, five Zonal Councils have been established. The chief ministers of the member states serve as the Vice-Chairman of the Council on rotational basis, the release said.

The Zonal Council provides a forum to resolve disputes and improve coordination between the Centre and the member states and Union Territories.

Meanwhile, officials said security has been tightened at Mahabalipuram ahead of the meeting. The movement of tourists has also been partially restricted.

Shah is expected to leave for Delhi on Thursday evening, officials said.

Former YSRCP leader to launch new party

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HYDERABAD: Former YSR Congress party MP in Rajya Sabha V Vijay Sai Reddy on Wednesday announced that he would launch a new political party in Andhra Pradesh soon.

Speaking to reporters at Tirumala, Sai Reddy said he would usher in a new kind of politics in Andhra Pradesh and establish a new political party to give voice to people's concerns.

He said he would announce his political roadmap later this month. "I sought the blessings of Lord Venkateswara for my political endeavour. I shall disclose complete details about his proposed party at a press conference in Vijayawada shortly," he



Vijay Sai Reddy

said.

The former MP said he had also prayed for the country to prosper without being adversely affected by El Nino conditions.

Sai Reddy, who was a founding member of the YSRCP, resigned from the party in January 2025, alleging that the party had lost the people's trust and the leader was surrounded by a coterie of people who were allegedly misleading him.

No room for caste bias in place of worship: HC

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BENGALURU: There can be no caste-based discrimination of devotees in a place of worship, the Madras High Court recently said while disposing of a plea alleging that non-Brahmin devotees were being treated differently at the Arulmigu Devaraja Swamy Temple in Tamil Nadu's Kancheepuram, particularly at the "Sri Manavala Mamunigal shrine," even as the temple administration denied any form of discrimination.

Justice G Jayachandran and Justice E Manoharan made the observation in an order passed on August 17.

The high court also quoted a verse from the Bhagwad Gita to say that God is "equally disposed towards all living beings"

and is neither partial to nor hateful of anyone.

"Before we proceed, it is necessary to extract the following from Bhagavad Gita: Chapter 9 Verse 29 [Translated] 'I am equally disposed to all living beings. I am neither partial to anyone nor do I hate anyone. But those who worship Me with devotion, they are in Me and I am in them.' - Lord Krishna In the eyes of God, all living beings are equal and God does not discriminate," the high court said.

The petitioner, a devotee and a resident of Kancheepuram district in Tamil Nadu, had alleged that non-Brahmin devotees were not allowed to use the main entrance of the Manavala Mamunigal shrine and were instead required to use a side entrance, while Brahmins were permitted to use the main

THE COURT WAS HEARING A PLEA ALLEGING CASTE DISCRIMINATION AT THE ARULMIGU DEVARAJA SWAMY TEMPLE IN TN

entrance.

He also alleged that non-Brahmins were prevented from reciting hymns in the temple's shrines and were made to stand outside the sannathi while receiving prasadam and therefrom, without being given satari (a sacred crown-shaped metal object with the Lord's footprints engraved on top). The alleged discrimination was particularly raised in connection with the 10-day birthday cele-

brations of Manavala Mamunigal.

The petitioner said this was discriminatory and against constitutional principles. He also submitted communications issued by the assistant commissioner of the Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments Department in 2003, which said there should be no discrimination between Brahmins and non-Brahmins in the distribution of theertham, satari and prasadam. In such communications, the assistant commissioner had also warned that strict action would follow if discrimination was found in the name of temple custom.

Denying the allegations of discrimination, the temple administration said the sub-shrines were small and even service holders could not fully

be accommodated inside them. It also assured the court that there will be no caste discrimination and that all members of the public will be "treated equally."

The administration also said the *Adhyabaga Mirasi* was a statutory right secured to the Thenkalai sect and carried remuneration and preferential honours. However, the devotees were not barred from singing any other hymns in any shrine while worshipping, it said.

The bench recorded these assurances and said they seemed adequate to resolve the petitioner's grievances. It also noted that the arrangement would allow the petitioner to recite hymns in the shrines and held that "there is no discrimination occurring by following any tradition."

J'khand students pause stir for 60 days after exams cancelled

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RANCHI: The job aspirants and student unions agitating against the alleged irregularities in Jharkhand recruitment exams for nearly a month in Ranchi on Wednesday announced a 60-day suspension of their indefinite sit-in after the state government conceded to almost all of their key demands.

The decision was announced by student representatives at a press conference at the Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium grounds, calling it a strategic pause to see if the government fulfils its promises. They further warned of resuming the protest if the government falls short in implementing them.

The development comes in the backdrop of chief minister Hemant Soren-led state government announcing the cancellation of 22 exams and ordered a probe into 23 others that were being conducted by the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) and the Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission (JSSC) and TSR Data Processing Private Limited (TDPL), an out-sourced agency, since 2014.

The probe was ordered based on findings from the ongoing probe by the Criminal Investigation Department (CID) of the state police into alleged irregularities, including paper leaks, bribery, and OMR sheet manipulations, in these exams.

The administration also expanded the ongoing CID probe to review all public recruitment exams held since 2014 and established a dedicated reform committee under a senior IAS officer to overhaul the examination infrastructure.

Talking to reporters, students' representative Kunal Singh said: "We are not going to end the agitation, but we have unanimously decided on a postponement to give the government an opportunity to honour its words given to students."

Singh further raised a demand for the government's legal support.



Protesters celebrate after the cancellation of recruitment exams on Wednesday.

"We also expect the government to support us in the court. Government should file a caveat and put its argument in favour of its cabinet decision properly," Singh said. "We also expect transparency in investigation the government has promised. If this does not happen, we will resume our protest."

While student leaders, including Devendra Nath Mahto and two others, broke their fasts after 16 days following the government's notifications, the student bodies emphasised that their ultimate demand for a probe into irregularities by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) remains on the table.

State minister Irfan Ansari reiterated that the government stood with the youth. "A consensus has been reached... the government is with the youth..." he told reporters.

Meanwhile, the students leaders also took out "Abhar Yatra" (thanksgiving) procession for all the students and guardians who supported their movement to bring reforms and overhaul in the system. The 'yatra' that started from Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium, the protest site, culminated at the Albert Ekka Chowk in the state capital.

"This is the result of a 16-day hunger strike and 24 days of 'satyagraha'. The 'satyagraha' started on August 24, and the hunger strike on August 2," student leader Mahto said, while also expressing his gratitude to chief minister Soren for addressing their concerns.

NTA tightens process for hiring of subject experts

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NEW DELHI: The National Testing Agency (NTA) is strengthening its process for hiring subject experts to prepare question papers for forthcoming national-level examinations. Those teachers who want to serve as subject experts will have to submit their educational and employment records, identity documents, conflict-of-interest and confidentiality declarations, and a No Objection Certificate (NOC) from their current employer, according to an internal NTA communication reviewed by HT.

The new requirements come a day after the testing body on Tuesday removed 600 subject experts as part of a rehaul of its examination system following the Union education ministry's directions to "fix accountability", conduct a thorough audit of its examination processes and submit a report on corrective action within 30 days—all reactions to a series of controversies involving NTA including paper leaks and incorrect questions in papers.

According to the circular, NTA has prescribed a four-stage process for empanelment of subject experts. In the first stage, it will verify the completeness of applications, qualifications, experience and supporting documents including Aadhar card, PAN card and the NOC.

The second stage will involve subject-matter evaluation, with NTA assessing academic standing, research record, previous experience in setting test papers, and depth of expertise. "The evaluation will be conducted by subject expert committees constituted by NTA," the agency said in its note.

Shortlisted candidates will then undergo "comprehensive background verification" in the

HC refuses to entertain plea to scrap NTA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court on Wednesday refused to entertain a petition of two NEET aspirants seeking the scrapping of the National Testing Agency (NTA) and an investigation into alleged discrepancies in the NEET-UG re-examination, observing that the reliefs they sought were personal in nature and did not qualify as PIL.

"From a perusal of the prayer clause, we find that it is a mixed bunch of prayers made seeking relief in respect of the petitioner and also all candidates who appeared in re-NEET exams. Such a writ petition with the mixture of prayers, in our opinion, cannot be entertained," a bench of chief justice DK Upadhyaya and justice Tejas Karia said in its order. **SHRUTI KAKKAR**

third stage, covering academic credentials, employment history, integrity declarations and conflict-of-interest disclosures, among other checks.

In the fourth stage, those selected following stage three will be formally empanelled for specific subject domains, levels and types of work. The empanelment will be valid for three years, subject to "satisfactory performance and continued integrity," according to the communication. "Empanelment may be terminated earlier in case of breach of

any term, on reasonable grounds, with appropriate notice," the NTA note said.

NTA and the Union education ministry did not respond to HT's queries.

NTA conducts 10 major national-level entrance examinations in multiple shifts throughout the year, and the papers for these are set by the empanelled subject experts, who are paid between ₹35,000 to ₹40,000 in a year. Their involvement lasts 7 to 15 days depending upon their roles in preparing question papers and examinations.

Paper setters have emerged the weak link in NTA's efforts to make its papers leak-proof. IIT Madras director V Kamakoti, part of the Nandan Nikelani headed committee that is looking at reforming the testing process, recently said that the integrity of paper setters is critical. However, the requirement of an NOC in the list of documents from serving faculty has raised concerns among some existing NTA subject experts.

One said the requirement could make the process vulnerable to institutional pressures. "Institute heads will give NOC to faculties who adhere to their ideologies. This is problematic."

Another, a faculty member in a state university said this could mean people not fit to become subject matter experts end up becoming that.

This person, who asked not to be named, also said the new process seemed cumbersome.

Previously, "NTA used to send mails to us showing its interest in hiring us as a subject expert on contractual basis. We were asked to just submit our CV and a declaration that our wards and relatives' children are not sitting examinations."

NTA has not publicly disclosed the total number of subject experts in its existing pool.

CWC plans to intensify outreach to students

Saubhadra Chatterji

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NEW DELHI: The Congress Working Committee (CWC) said on Wednesday it would double down on the party's outreach to students by extending Leader of the Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi's "Chhatron ki Goonj" programme to 800 towns, launch a grassroots agitation against alleged donation theft at the Ram Mandir and resolved not to sing the full version of the national song Vande Mataram at party events.

Following a four-hour-long meeting of the party's apex top executive body, Congress general secretary (organisation) KC Venugopal said paper leaks and students' issues are the party's top priority. HT on August 18 had reported that CWC would chart an expansion plan of Chhatron ki Goonj (Voice of Students).

The move comes in the backdrop of the Congress launching an intense protest against the government in the recently concluded monsoon session of Parliament over the use of force against protesting students in New Delhi on July 20. The students' protest, headed by Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), came in the wake of allegations of irregularities, including paper leak, in the NEET-UG 2026.

Number one issue is paper leak. The agitation of students and the way in which the government reacted to it made it clear that the government was on the back foot. We have decided that LoP Rahul Gandhi's Chhatron ki Goonj and his direct involvement of agitation, especially the surgical strike on PM's house, created a big impact. The CWC decided that we will continue Chhatron ki Goonj in around 800 cities small and medium cities. Rahul Gandhi will attend some of these programmes," Venugopal said.

During the meeting, Rahul Gandhi urged party leaders to meet students and common people, while party chief Mallikarjun Kharge asked Congress-led state governments to consult experts to prepare a blueprint for education and exam reforms in their respective states.

Venugopal also announced the party's decision to sing the abridged version of the national song Vande Mataram—and not the full version as stipulated by the government for official functions—citing the decision of stalwarts such as Rabindranath Tagore, Sardar Patel, Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose, Jawaharlal Nehru and others in 1937. The decision also comes amid row over the alleged conduct of senior leaders Sonia and Rahul Gandhi during the rendition of the national song at the Congress headquarters on the Independence Day.

Defending the decision to sing only the first two stanzas of the national song, Venugopal said: "Vande Mataram and the National Anthem are emotional issues for us. But it is a political issue for the BJP." In the meeting, three senior leaders Anand Sharma, Digvijaya Singh and Tariq Anwar said there would be no compromise on the party's



(From left) Congress leaders Sonia Gandhi, Mallikarjun Kharge, Rahul Gandhi and KC Venugopal during the CWC meeting. HT PHOTO

stance on Vande Mataram issue.

The Centre issued a circular in February this year to sing all six stanzas of the national song in official programmes.

In his opening remarks, Kharge laid emphasis on students' issues. He said youth is "the primary focus" of the party's "collective concern" and pitched for a "comprehensive, and time-bound 'Education-to-Employment Roadmap' for the youth," pitching for a policy shift to benefit Gen Z.

Invoking Rajiv Gandhi government's push for information technology and lowering the voting age, Kharge said: "Thanks to the extensive efforts of the Congress since Independence, the country gained access to affordable and accessible education, thereby opening the path to socio-economic development for the poor and marginalised sections of society. However, over the last 12 years, the Modi government has devastated the future of the youth. Instead of opening new schools, 94,000 schools have shut down in recent years. Driven by a race towards privatisation, higher education is becoming increasingly expensive and out of reach for ordinary families. Educational institutions are being taken over by RSS affiliates."

The Congress president narrated how after completing their education when young people set out in search of jobs, they are confronted with issues like paper leaks, recruitment exam scams, and delays in appointments and students from poor and disadvantaged backgrounds suffer the most in this situation. "The anger brewing among the youth across the country is not a recent phenomenon. This government has never spared the time to listen to them; instead, it has consistently sought temporary fixes to sidestep the problem. Consequently, they have been forced to take to the streets. The Congress party has incorporated their concerns into its agenda. Rahul Gandhi has brought their issues to the national stage through the Chhatron Ki Goonj initiative," he added.

Kharge also raised the issue of "purification" of a stage in Uttarakhand's Haldwani by some "BJP elements" after he attended an event there. Rahul Gandhi intervened and asked party's social media chief Supriya Shrinete to send him reports on how party leaders were amplifying the issues raised by Kharge.

In a veiled criticism of senior Congress lawmaker Shashi Tharoor, who was also present in the

meeting, Kharge said some leaders who are "good looking and articulate" and therefore appear regularly on TV, don't take the party's line.

Referring to the allegations of donation theft at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, Venugopal said: "Everyone knows chanda chori (donation theft) is a sentimental issue for the people. Those who are using Ram Mandir for polarising people now stands totally exposed. We are going to take it up the issue at grassroots level, at chaupals and village panchayat level."

In the first meeting of the extended CWC after the tumultuous monsoon session that was partially washed out over the Opposition's protest against police action on students and the Ram temple donation theft allegation, 33 members participated in the meeting while 88 people attended it.

The CWC also discussed the Chinese incursion in Arunachal Pradesh and lashed out at the government. "Those who talk of desh-bhakti (patriotism), they first surrendered to America (and) now they surrendered to China," Venugopal said and reiterated that the party wants implementation of women's quota in the current 543 Lok Sabha seats.

Channi skips meeting

Meanwhile, former Punjab chief minister Charanjit Singh Channi was conspicuous by his absence during the CWC meeting, where the preparations for the upcoming Punjab assembly polls also featured in discussion.

A senior Punjab Congress leader said Channi was schedule to sit for an examination at Panjab University on Thursday. "We will wish him well. May he complete his PhD and become a doctor," Congress MP Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa said.

Channi's absence comes against the backdrop of a bitter internal battle within the Punjab Congress ahead of the assembly polls. The former chief minister wants to be appointed as the party's Punjab unit chief, a post currently held by Amrinder Singh Raja Warring. Channi had also stayed away from various organisational programmes during 10-day Punjab visit of party's state in-charge Bhupesh Baghel, who was trying to secure a truce between the two sides. When asked about Channi not attending the CWC meeting due to his exam, Baghel said: "Is what he saying wrong? Then what is the news here?"

Nabin to meet new team; rejigs likely in apex bodies

HT Correspondent

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NEW DELHI: The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) is likely to recast its Parliamentary Board, the party's highest decision-making body, and the Central Election Committee (CEC), which takes a call on candidate selections for various polls, people aware of the matter said. The party has recently announced a new team of national office bearers.

Both the apex bodies were last rejigged in 2022. To be sure, the last Parliamentary Board reshuf-

file in August 2022 came around eight years after the previous reconstitution in 2014.

The rejig in Parliamentary Board and CEC is expected soon, although no dates have been officially decided for the process, the people cited above said.

Separately, the newly appointed 65 national office bearers, whose names were announced on August 17, are scheduled to meet party president Nitin Nabin on Saturday.

"This will be a formal meeting of the party president and his new team...the next step will be to



Nitin Nabin

allocate work and states to the office bearers," said a party functionary.

According to the party's constitution, the Parliamentary Board consists of the party president as its chairperson and 10

other members, one of whom must be the leader of the party in Parliament. One of the general secretaries shall be nominated as secretary of the board.

At present, the Parliamentary Board has 12 members, including Prime Minister Narendra Modi, and Union ministers Rajnath Singh, Amit Shah and JP Nadda.

"There is a possibility that some senior leaders from election-bound states could be included or a sitting CM also brought on board. But the party will stick to giving representation to women and ensure caste-balance," said

the functionary cited above. At present, Sudha Yadav is the only woman in the board. The CEC, which consists of the Parliamentary Board and eight other members, at present has 15 members, including two women—Sudha Yadav and former women's wing chief Vanathi Srinivasan.

The national executive, which has 120 members, and the national council, which includes representatives from state councils, former party presidents and leaders of legislative parties, will also be reconstituted, the people said.

NCERT reconstitutes textbook team for classes 11, 12 pol science

Press Trust of India

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NEW DELHI: The National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT) has reconstituted the Textbook Development Team for class 11 and 12 political science with a mandate to integrate "cultural rootedness", Indian knowledge systems and inclusion, with at least four of the members having direct or indirect links with the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS).

The team has been asked to develop the class 11 textbook by November and the class 12 book by July next year.

The textbook team will be led by academic and political analyst Sandeep Shastri, vice president of Karnataka-based deemed university Nitte.

Among the members of the textbook development team are at least four academics and educationists with direct or indirect documented backgrounds in the RSS-affiliated Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).

Yadunath Deshpande, now a senior consultant with the ministry of education, has a long-standing organisational background in the ABVP.

The organisation's own records identify him as its joint state organising secretary for Maharashtra in the past. He subsequently served as an organis-

THE NEW TEAM INCLUDES AT LEAST 4 MEMBERS HAVING DIRECT OR INDIRECT LINKS WITH THE RSS

ing secretary in the ABVP's Mumbai-Konkan structure. His LinkedIn profile also describes him as political consultant for BJP.

Prashant Divekar has a long-standing association with Pune-based Jnana Prabodhini, an RSS-affiliated institution. It was founded in 1962 by Vinayak Vishwanath, an RSS member and pracharak.

In his profile on the National Council for Teacher Education's National Mission for Mentoring portal, Divekar describes his approach as being "rooted in Bharatiya educational philosophy" and says he has contributed to the National Curriculum Framework. Vandana Mishra, professor at JNU's Centre for Political Studies, is a former national secretary of the ABVP.

Ravi Rameshchandra Shukla, Associate Professor at JNU's Centre for Comparative Politics and Political Theory, has been a member of the editorial board of the Indian Journal of Democratic Governance, published by the Indian Institute of Democratic Leadership-Rambhau Mhalgi Prabod-

hini, which is an RSS affiliate. In 2021, Devendra Fadnavis had become its president.

Shukla has also undertaken research centred on cultural and spiritual nationalism. He is the principal investigator of an ICSSR-funded JNU project titled "The Role of Fests in Shaping of Spiritual and Cultural Nationalism of Bharat: A Study of Kumbha and Magh Mela".

The team also comprises Prakash Kandpal from JNU, Needhi Gupta from National Law University, Chetan Singhai from Chanakya University, Sukanishka Vatsa from Delhi University, Satish Kumar from IGNOU, Deevanshu Shrivastava from National University of Study and Research in Law, Pranav Gupta from Jindal Global Law School, Nanda Kishor from Pondicherry University and Swapna Prabhu from Utkal University.

According to an NCERT notification, the team will consult other curricular area groups to ensure linkages with other grades, interdisciplinary among subjects, and the integration of multilingual perspectives.

"Review of each of the textbooks will take place to oversee the integration of cross-cutting themes, such as cultural rootedness, Indian knowledge systems, inclusion, educational technology, assessment, etc," the notification issued by NCERT Director Dinesh Prasad Saklani said.

{ NEET EXAM LEAK }

TN withdraws protest-related circular

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI: The Tamil Nadu government on Wednesday withdrew a controversial circular directing that students be prevented from participating in protests of Leftist groups and parties, including the online collective Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), after it sparked a row.

In the circular on Saturday, the commissioner of collegiate education directed college principals to initiate interdepartmental coordination and integrated action with the school education and higher education departments, police, and district administrations to prevent students from participating in protests. It asked for immediate details of the action taken. On Wednesday, the directorate said the circular has been withdrawn.

The Students' Federation of India (SFI), the Communist Party of India (Marxist)'s student wing, called the withdrawal of the circular a victory for democratic rights of students. "This victory is not just a win for SFI's protest. It is a democratic victory demonstrating that if students unite and raise their voice for their rights, they can question the government," said SFI's Tamil Nadu chief C Mrithula. "We will not let students' voices be suppressed. We will continue to fight for democratic rights."



C Joseph Vijay

Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK) chief Anbumani Ramadoss condemned the state government's attempt to curtail the democratic rights of students fighting for justice. "Education and social justice determine the future of students. If either is adversely affected, it is the duty of the students to protest against it."

He said the government's responsibility is to ensure that such protests do not lead to any law-and-order problems. Ramadoss said it cannot prevent students from participating in them. "Attempting to stop students from participating in protests is an infringement of their democratic rights," he said.

He referred to school education minister A Rajmohan's participation in a student protest against the NEET exam paper leak in Chennai. "On the one hand, the minister himself expresses support for protests. On the other, the government is preventing students from participating in protests. What kind of double standards are these?"

Vijay: All MLAs to get cars, ₹1 lakh allowance

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay announced on Wednesday that his government will provide every legislator in the state an official vehicle and a monthly ₹1-lakh allowance for fuel, maintenance and driver expenses, saying that the number of first-time MLAs who don't have their own vehicles has significantly increased. As many as 110 MLAs are first-timers.

He said the decision was made to help the MLAs take up constituency development work. Assembly Speaker JCD Prabhakar said the scheme has been announced for all MLAs.

The decision was welcomed by legislators across party lines, however, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), criticised it, saying that MLAs who own vehicles should be excluded from the scheme.

In a suo motu response to Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) MLA LE Jothamani's request on August 12 for a vehicle—as he found it difficult to travel to the Secretariat every day—the CM said several MLAs don't own a personal vehicle, making it difficult for them to

inspect and review constituency work. "I am pleased to announce that vehicles will be provided by the government to all members of the legislative assembly," the CM said. "The government running an honest administration without bribery must fulfil the basic needs of its members," he added.

Vijay said a monthly allowance of ₹75,000 would be provided to cover expenses including driver salary, fuel, and vehicle maintenance. Additionally, ₹25,000 will be provided to appoint an assistant for office work. "...necessary amendments will be made to the relevant Act and official orders will be issued," Vijay said.

Salary, allowances and perks to legislators are regulated through a state-specific law.

Meanwhile, DMK spokesperson Saravanan Annadurai said, "The TVK government wants to splurge public money on luxury, which is not a priority."

Former DMK MLA and medical wing secretary Ezhilan said the government should provide vehicles only to those who do not own one. "Those MLAs who declared in the election affidavit that they own a vehicle should not be given a vehicle," he said.

INDIA, PALESTINE SIGN 2 MoUs IN DEVELOPMENT COOPERATION

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NEW DELHI: India and Palestine on Wednesday signed agreements on setting up a 200-bed super speciality hospital and a vocational training centre as a top Indian diplomat met the senior Palestinian leadership to discuss development cooperation in a range of areas.

Sripriya Ranganathan, secretary for overseas Indian affairs, reaffirmed India's "consistent support for the Palestinian people and [a] negotiated two-state solution" during a meeting with Palestinian foreign minister Varun Aghabekian Shahin on Tuesday, according to a readout from India's representative office in Ramallah.

Ranganathan participated in the groundbreaking ceremony for the 200-bed Indian super speciality hospital in Jenin along with Palestinian Prime Minister Mohammad Mustafa and other dignitaries.

The two sides also signed the bilateral memorandum of understanding (MoU) for the hospital, which will include a trauma centre, and another MoU for establishing a Technical and Vocational Education and Training Centre within the Palestinian National Printing Press.

The hospital will serve Jenin and neighbouring governorates, including Tulkarm and Tubas.

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HC backs name-based court record searches

Shruti Kakkar

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NEW DELHI: The Delhi high court on Wednesday observed that permitting name-based searches across legal databases and domains for court records is in the public interest, and that disabling such searches would pose a “herculean” challenge.

A bench of justices C Hari Shankar and Vinod Kumar said that restricting searches to case-specific details alone would make it difficult for users to locate and access judgments.

“If you access the judgement by going into the subject involved, it is a herculean effort to do that. It is not even remotely a substitute to remove the name (based search). With the writ petition number, case details, you will never be able to access any judgment. If the single judge says that one of the considerations which can give the balance is public interest, public interest is in favour of access to this,” the judges said.

The court made these remarks while hearing an appeal filed by Indian Kanoon against a single judge’s May 29 ruling directing the legal database platform to de-index and disable name-based searches across all its platforms and domains for court records and news articles of certain individuals to give effect to the right to be forgotten.

De-indexing is a directive issued to a private platform that does not result in the erasure of a judicial record, which remains accessible on court websites and legal databases. It merely removes the concerned name as a searchable retrieval key, thereby restricting easy access to the record through name-based searches.

On May 29, the single judge created a judicial roadmap for enforcing the right to be forgotten, setting down detailed legal principles for when names can be removed from search results of search engines and legal databases or masked in court records. The single judge, while considering petitions filed by 39 individuals including persons acquitted of criminal charges, parties to matrimonial disputes, and individuals whose names appeared incidentally in judicial records despite not being parties to the proceedings, directed de-indexing.

HC WAS HEARING APPEAL AGAINST A SINGLE JUDGE’S RULING WHICH CREATED JUDICIAL ROADMAP FOR ENFORCING THE RIGHT TO BE FORGOTTEN

ing the right to be forgotten, setting down detailed legal principles for when names can be removed from search results of search engines and legal databases or masked in court records. The single judge, while considering petitions filed by 39 individuals including persons acquitted of criminal charges, parties to matrimonial disputes, and individuals whose names appeared incidentally in judicial records despite not being parties to the proceedings, directed de-indexing.

While recognising the right to be forgotten as an integral facet of the fundamental right to privacy, the judge said that the courts while considering the de-indexing relief must assess the information’s character, outcome of the concluded proceedings, an individual’s public role of the individual concerned, and the accuracy and continuing relevance of the information.

In the high court, the platform’s lawyer Arvind Datar, submitted that by virtue of this direction in the verdict all the reports concerning a person will have to be removed. In its petition, the platform stated that the single judge laid down an arbitrary standard for de-indexing and disabling name-based searches in cases where information is considered no longer relevant or lacking a

legitimate public purpose.

Senior advocate Akhil Sibal, appearing for an individual who was discharged in the case 10 years ago, opposed the appeal, submitting that only Indian Kanoon had challenged the verdict, while the other intermediaries against whom the direction was issued had complied with it. “It (directions in the judgement) have been implemented across the board. The idea behind de-indexing is to remove the level of accessibility,” Sibal submitted.

The court fixed September 2 as the next date of hearing after the parties said that the same raised “serious issues” on various aspects including the right to privacy.

The platform’s petition contended that the concepts of “relevance” and “legitimate public purpose” are broad, vague, and undefined, and that the absence of a clear and exhaustive framework identifying the categories of cases in which names should be masked could lead to inconsistent judicial approaches. This, the platform argued, risks arbitrary censorship and unjustifiably restricts the retrievability and searchability of court records.

The petition further stated that the verdict, directed global de-indexing without an evidentiary fact-finding assessment of harm, and merely on bare assertion of harm. It added that the verdict has arbitrarily and in violation of the fundamental right to equality, made directions for disabling name based search functionality only against one legal database even though there are several other case management platforms available online for cataloging and searching judgement/orders of various Indian court and tribunals.

The direction, it said, creates a classification discrimination against the platform.

RAJ’S FREE CANCER DRUG SURFACES IN DELHI BLACK MKT

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BIKANER/JAIPUR: A batch of an expensive cancer drug supplied through Rajasthan’s government free-medicine programme to four centres in the state has surfaced in the alleged black market in Delhi, prompting the state government to order a detailed inquiry into its procurement, distribution and utilisation.

Health minister Gajendra Singh Khimsar on Wednesday took note of the alleged illegal sale of the drug and directed officials to conduct a factual investigation into the entire matter. He said black marketing or unauthorised sale of costly life-saving medicines meant for patients at government hospitals would not be tolerated.

The case came to light after the Delhi Police Crime Branch’s Inter State Cell arrested members of an alleged interstate drug syndicate on Tuesday and seized 22 vials of expensive cancer medicines, including Darzalex, Imfinzi, Eribut, Bavencio, Adcetris and Keytruda. Police also recovered ₹27.19 lakh cash and further searches are on.

Four seized vials of Bavencio 200mg/10ml (avelumab) have emerged as the key link to Rajasthan. The batch was manufactured in February 2025 and is due to expire in January 2028. Verification with the manufacturer established that the batch had been supplied to the Rajasthan Medical Services Corporation Limited for government use.

The government has constituted an inquiry committee to ascertain how the government-supplied medicine reached the black market. Investigators suspect the alleged syndicate’s network may have extended from Rajasthan and Delhi to Vashi in Mumbai.

Leader of Opposition Tikaram Jyoti demanded that the probe be expanded to all government-run hospitals in Rajasthan.

1 suspended over detergent in midday meal

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PATNA: The Nalanda district administration on Wednesday suspended the headmaster of a government school and issued show-cause notices to several officials, including the district programme officer of the mid-day meal scheme, after around three dozen students fell ill after eating a mid-day meal allegedly contaminated with detergent.

Three cooks, at Middle School in Parasi in the Noorsarai police station area, who prepared the meal have also been dismissed, district education officer Nalanda Hem Raj said, adding, a four-member team has been formed to probe the incident.

“In our initial probe, it has come



Students at a hospital after consuming a midday meal in Nalanda on Wednesday.

out the cooks were responsible for the lapse and had added detergent in the food by mistaking it for salt. All the three cooks have been dismissed and the headmaster of the middle school Shailendra Kumar has been put under suspension,” Raj said.

The served meal consisted of

rice and a soybean dish.

The probe team comprises the sub-divisional officer and sub-divisional police officer of Bihar Sharif, the district education officer and the head of Noorsarai primary health centre. It is likely to submit its report to Nalanda magistrate Udit Singh within three days, officials aware of the matter said.

The students fell ill on Tuesday after consuming the meal at the school. They complained of dizziness and began vomiting. They were taken to Sadar hospital in Bihar Sharif, where they received treatment before being discharged on Wednesday.

Bihar rural development minister Shrawan Kumar visited the hospital and met the affected students.

Officials said some students had already eaten when others com-

plained that the food did not contain enough salt. The containers of salt and detergent powder were reportedly kept at the same place in the kitchen, leading the cook to allegedly mistake detergent for salt and add it to the food. “The block education officer, Noorsarai has been asked to lodge an FIR regarding the incident,” Raj said.

“It is a major lapse and we have already showcaused officials associated with monitoring of the mid-day meal at the block and district level. Action would be taken once the probe committee report comes,” said a senior state education department official.

Earlier in May, more than 100 students at a middle school in Mahisi block of Saharsa district fell ill after eating contaminated food.

5 DIE IN GUJARAT AFTER DRINKING SPURIOUS LIQUOR

AHMEDABAD: At least five people have died and 18 are undergoing treatment at Sir T Hospital in Gujarat’s Bhavnagar and other hospitals after allegedly consuming spurious liquor at Kharadi village in Ghogha taluka, a senior police officer said on Wednesday.

According to police, they have detained 10 suspected bootleggers for questioning. The incident came to light on Tuesday after people who had consumed the liquor started falling ill.

“A preliminary investigation found that a bootlegger from the Vartej in Bhavnagar district and a man from Madhya Pradesh were allegedly selling spurious liquor together. They allegedly filled bottles bearing the Royal Stag label with inferior-quality liquor, mixed it with water and passed it off as genuine liquor,” according to the officer.

Pune man arrested for raping, killing 10-yr-old

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PUNE: A 10-year-old girl was allegedly raped and murdered in Maharashtra’s Pune district, police said on Wednesday, adding that a 25-year-old man has been arrested over the case.

The incident took place around 2 pm on Tuesday in Pimpalwadi village of Junnar tehsil, police said. The girl’s parents, who are agricultural labourers, were away for work. When she was not found at home, police were informed around 6-7 pm.

According to police, the accused, a farm labourer and neighbour of the victim’s family, allegedly lured the girl on the pretext of taking her to eat guava and led her about 1 to 1.5 km away from the village. Pune rural superintendent of police

Sandip Singh Gill said, “The accused lured the girl on the pretext of taking her to eat guava and took her away from the village. He allegedly took her to an agricultural field, allegedly raped her, and strangled her to death.” The accused, a Class 4 dropout, has no previous criminal record, police said.

SDPO Dhananjay Patil said, “During interrogation, he confessed and led the police team to the spot where the girl’s body was found.” The post-mortem examination is underway.

Deputy CM Sunetra Pawar called the incident “extremely shocking and unfortunate”. “I will make a special request to chief minister and home minister Devendra Fadnis to have the case tried in a fast-track court so that the accused is punished at the earliest,” she stated.

CBI ARRESTS I&B MINISTRY OFFICER FOR TAKING BRIBE

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has arrested a senior officer posted in the Union ministry of information and broadcasting while accepting ₹10 lakh bribe through his wife for clearing a renewal file of a private company that handles the social media of the ministry, agency officials said on Wednesday.

The accused, identified as Sandeep Choudhary, is posted as a deputy controller of accounts in I&B ministry (MIB).

On August 14, when the firm contacted Choudhary in connection with contract renewal, he “demanded an undue advantage from the complainant to process the file expeditiously,” the FIR said. The agency on Tuesday caught the 2020 batch ICAS officer for accepting ₹10 lakh bribe through his wife, a CBI spokesperson said in a statement.

Collectors to now decide citizenship applications in border states: MHA

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NEW DELHI: The Union government on Wednesday amended the Citizenship Rules to empower collectors in six border states and two Union territories to decide applications for Indian citizenship under Section 6B of the Citizenship Act.

The change applies to Gujarat, Rajasthan, Punjab, West Bengal, Assam, Tripura, and the Union territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh. Collectors will now receive, scrutinise and dispose of citizenship applications submitted electronically by applicants ordinarily residing in these areas.

Under the rules notified in March 2024, the applications were handled by empowered commit-

CHANGE APPLIES TO GUJARAT, RAJASTHAN, PUNJAB, WEST BENGAL, ASSAM, TRIPURA, J&K AND LADAKH

tees headed by the director of census operations of the state or Union territory concerned. The committees included representatives of the Subsidiary Intelligence Bureau (SIB), the Foreigners Regional Registration Office, National Informatics Centre, the post office and the railways.

In a gazette notification issued on Wednesday, the ministry of home affairs said, “...applicants

ordinarily residing in the States of Gujarat, Rajasthan, Punjab, West Bengal, Assam (except tribal area), Tripura (except tribal area), Union territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh, an application for registration or naturalisation under section 6B shall be submitted by the applicant in electronic form to the Collector having jurisdiction, who shall be the competent authority to receive, scrutinize and dispose of such applications.”

Collectors will verify documents submitted by applicants, conduct inquiries, administer the Oath of Allegiance and satisfy themselves about the applicant’s eligibility, the notification said. “On being satisfied with the suitability of the applicant that he is a fit and proper person to be registered or naturalised, the Collector shall

grant him the citizenship of India,” it said.

Through a separate notification, the home ministry said its March 11, 2024 order relating to empowered committees or district committees would no longer apply to the specified states and Union territories. Applications pending before the empowered committees will be transferred to the concerned collectors, it said.

The Citizenship Rules were notified in March 2024, four years after Parliament passed the Citizenship (Amendment) Act, 2019 (CAA), which provides a pathway to Indian citizenship for members of Hindu, Sikh, Buddhist, Jain, Parsi and Christian communities from Afghanistan, Bangladesh and Pakistan who entered India on or before December 31, 2014.

GADKARI: GOVT TO USE GST TO TRACK SUBCONTRACTING IN HIGHWAY WORKS

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NEW DELHI: Union road transport and highways minister Nitin Gadkari on Wednesday said the government will use Goods and Services Tax (GST) records to track layers of subcontracting in highway projects and is preparing rules to limit the extent to which contractors can subcontract work, amid concerns about projects being awarded at steeply discounted bids and the subsequent dilution of quality.

The minister said excessive subcontracting was contributing to quality problems and that contractors sometimes offered explanations such as rain when confronted with poor work. “Earning money is not a crime. If you do business, contractorship, you must earn some money. But while doing the work, there must be quality work,” he said.

“Nowadays, it can be known which GST was filed for which work and by whom. So I am issuing an order now establishing the rules on what percentage a contractor can subcontract,” Gadkari said at a FICCI event in New Delhi.

In war on drugs, NCB to focus on foreigners involved in trafficking

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NEW DELHI: The Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB), in coordination with other central agencies and state police forces, will conduct a nationwide crackdown on foreigners staying illegally in India and involved in drug trafficking, officials aware of the matter said. The move is part of the government’s ongoing war on drugs.

The NCB has written to the anti-narcotics task forces of all states for the crackdown in September, the official said on the condition of anonymity.

“Intelligence will be shared by central agencies, and joint operations will be conducted in places where foreigners staying illegally are involved in the drug trade. The NCB has also identified places where such foreigners are staying. For example, in the NCR, several border areas near Delhi, including parts of Greater Noida and Ghaziabad, have emerged as new hotspots for foreigners staying illegally and dealing in drugs. Earlier,

there were other hotspots, but they have changed over the last few years. This crackdown is not targeted at any specific country or community, but at all those living illegally and involved in the drug trade,” the official said.

The strategy to identify foreigners involved in the drug trade was among the key measures outlined in the government’s Vision Documents 2026-27, a three-year, target-specific plan aligned with its vision of making India drug-free by 2047 — a pledge made by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Bringing back fugitives settled abroad who are allegedly working to pump drugs into India is another key strategy under the three-year plan. Central agencies, including the NCB, have drawn up a list of 25 such fugitives, described as key players in the drug trade, three of whom have already been brought back. “There are different measures in the plan. One involves jail inspections and a crackdown on smuggling inside jails and on drug gangs formed there. This, too, will happen in the next few months,” the official added.

100 MURDER CASES TAKEN AWAY FROM UP JUDGE WHO GAVE 22 DEATH PENALTIES

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MEERUT: The district and sessions judge in Muzaffarnagar has transferred 100 murder cases pending before judge Ravikumar Diwakar, who sentenced 22 convicts in nine cases to death between April and August this year, people aware of the matter said on Wednesday.

The recalled cases will now be heard by the district and sessions judge. Assistant district government counsel (Criminal) Kuldeep Kumar, representing the prosecution in the fast track court, confirmed that all 100 files recalled by district judge Birendra Kumar Singh relate to murder cases.

Former District Bar Association presidents Anil Jindal and Shyamveer Singh confirmed that cases in which they were representing parties had been recalled by the district and sessions judge.

According to them, the files concern pending trials, while cases in which judgments have already been delivered will not be affected by the move.

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Gor meets Omar, says J&K an important part of India

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SRINAGAR: US ambassador Sergio Gor on Wednesday described Jammu and Kashmir as an "important part of India" during a visit to Srinagar, prompting Pakistan to summon the senior-most American diplomat in Islamabad to register a protest.

Gor, the first US ambassador to travel to Jammu and Kashmir in six years, made the remarks after a meeting with chief minister Omar Abdullah. He also indicated that the US could look into downgrading a travel advisory for Kashmir in view of the improvement in the situation in the region.

"This is an important part of India and so I am here visiting for the first time. It is an incredibly beautiful place and I'm thrilled to be here, thrilled to see this place," Gor said while speaking to the local media along with Abdullah.

Gor, who is also the US special envoy for South and Central Asia, noted that the US has a practice of reviewing travel warnings that it issues for its citizens and said: "I cannot make any big announcements here today but it is something we are going to look at."



J&K CM Omar Abdullah during a meeting with US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor in Srinagar on Wednesday. X/OMARABDULLAH

Both the Central and Jammu and Kashmir governments "have made some incredible steps in keeping this area safer", he said. "We will be looking at if the travel warning that is recommended by the US is something that should be downgraded because as I said earlier this is a beautiful area. I think a lot of Americans would enjoy coming here and seeing the beauty," Gor said.

If the US state department downgrades the threat level, it could turn out to be a major boost for the tourism sector in Kashmir. Tourism accounts for 7% of the state GDP.

Hours later, Pakistan's foreign ministry summoned the US charge d'affaires in Islamabad, Natalie Baker, and served her a "strong demarche" on Gor's visit to Kashmir and his "incorrect statement regarding the status of the disputed territory".

A statement from Pakistan's foreign ministry described Gor's remarks on the status of Jammu and Kashmir as "factually incorrect".

"Pakistan strongly condemned and categorically rejected the characterisation of Jammu and Kashmir as a 'part of India'," the statement said. The foreign ministry contended that Gor's "irresponsible statement...negated the long-standing and well-documented position of the United States" on the Kashmir issue and "ran contrary to the United States' commitment to supremacy of international law and the UN Charter".

The statement added: "While appreciating President Donald Trump's offer to mediate between India and Pakistan to resolve the Jammu and Kashmir dispute in the aftermath of Marka-e-Haq, the US side was urged to ensure that its public statements remain consistent with the disputed status of Jammu and Kashmir."

It is rare for US diplomats to publicly comment on the Kashmir issue. The US has traditionally maintained that India and Pakistan should handle all bilateral issues, while New Delhi has consistently ruled out any third party mediation, especially on issues such as Kashmir.

Several Kashmiri politicians, including opposition leader Mehbooba Mufti, had raised the US travel advisory for Kashmir amid Gor's first visit to the region. Mufti said on social media that Gor should "review and withdraw the highest level travel advisory against visiting Kashmir" as thousands of families in the region depend on tourism. The US travel advisory, she said, acts as "a wall between Kashmir and the world".

Following his meeting with Gor, Abdullah told the media: "We had an opportunity to discuss the relations between our two countries, but with specific focus on what the US can do with Jammu and Kashmir."

He added: "There are obviously certain legacy issues that, over time, we will be working to resolve but we look forward to taking this conversation further."

(With inputs from Mir Ehsan in Srinagar)

'Lack of demarcation causing confusion near China border'

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NEW DELHI: Parliamentary affairs minister Kiren Rijiju on Wednesday said people living on either side of the Line of Actual Control (LAC) in some areas of Arunachal Pradesh have differing perceptions of the boundary because it is not demarcated, leading to some confusion.

He trashed reports suggesting that China had intruded 60km into Indian territory.

"It is not like they (China) came and captured our village. That is not the case. On certain land, they have cast an eye because there is no demarcation. Our people believe that our land extends further ahead, while the villages situated on the China side, including Tibetan and local people, claim that their land extends deep inside here. So, there is confusion," he said in an interview to news agency IANS.

The comments came days after the Ministry of External Affairs said that the state of border affairs has ramifications for overall India-China ties, adding that the two sides have agreed to use existing diplomatic and military mechanisms to "avoid misunderstanding and miscalculation" along the border.

On August 12, External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal made the remarks while responding to a question on the



Kiren Rijiju

military situation between India and China in the Arunachal Pradesh sector and whether recent reports of a standoff had been taken up diplomatically with China.

The Army and the ITBP have significantly strengthened their patrolling compared to earlier, Rijiju said.

"And the village that has been built at a location ahead of Longju, where there is a valley and a river confluence, is where the Chinese PLA constructed some structures and built a few buildings resembling a village. That land was occupied in 1959... Then, in 1962, they further consolidated and established their presence at that place. Right now, at our border point, our post is also present there. Travel and movement between China and India there have remained closed since after 1962. However, on the high ridges at

the top, Chinese military activity has certainly increased," he said.

"The concerns raised by our villagers regarding that are justified, and we should take them very seriously. But telling such lies that they have entered 60 kilometres inside, and posting unrelated photos from Bangladesh and elsewhere to claim that the Chinese Army has penetrated 60 kilometres inside Arunachal, spreading such misinformation lowers the morale of our Army personnel and security forces stationed there, and creates confusion in the country. This is not right," he added.

The two countries are engaged in the painstaking process of rebuilding their relations, which plummeted to a six-decade low in 2020 following a military face-off in the Ladakh sector of the LAC and a violent clash at Galwan Valley in June that year that left 20 Indian soldiers and at least four Chinese troops dead.

There is no clarity on the current status of the standoff in the Arunachal Pradesh sector, though people familiar with the situation earlier said on condition of anonymity that the problems first emerged in the remote Taksin area of Upper Subansiri district in early July. There were a few face-offs between Indian and Chinese troops in July and matters took a more serious turn towards the end of last month, the people said.

SC: TAKE A CALL ON GRAHAM STAINES MURDER CONVICT'S REMISSION PLEA

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Wednesday told the Odisha government that it will not tolerate any further delay in dealing with the remission plea of Graham Staines' murder convict Dara Singh, observing that if the Sentence Review Board (SRB) fails to take a decision in two weeks, the court will take a call.

Posting the petition filed by Singh to September 2, a bench of justices Manoj Misra and Vijay Bhishnoi said, "We cannot tolerate this that the SRB is avoiding taking a decision. Has the Board taken a decision either way you must tell us or we will take our own decision."

The state, represented by advocate PV Yogeswaran, told the court that the SRB, based on a letter from the Directorate of Prisons, is waiting for a report from the District Jail, Keonjhar, where Singh is lodged.

The bench said, "We are not concerned to know which authority you are communicating with. You take a decision either way but don't dodge these proceedings by showing us a letter... This matter has been adjourned time and time again to enable the SRB to take a decision on the plea of remission of sentence awarded to the petitioner who is incarcerated for a period beyond 26 years."

Union mins get report card on their social media performance

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NEW DELHI: Members of the Union Council of Ministers received an analysis of their performance on four major social media platforms during Wednesday's cabinet meeting chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and were also given instructions to expand their footprint across networks and scale up outreach, said people aware of the matter.

To bolster the government's outreach on the ground, the PM is also learnt to have told the ministers to visit public schools and universities for "freewheeling chats" with students. Union ministers Pralhad Joshi and Mansukh Mandaviya will coordinate the outreach which is aimed at Gen Z and Gen Alpha, said people quoted above.

The analysis evaluated their posts and interactions on Facebook, LinkedIn, X and Instagram between May and August 15, said one person. Wednesday's instruction comes amid efforts

THE PM IS LEARNT TO HAVE TOLD THE MINISTERS TO VISIT PUBLIC SCHOOLS, UNIVERSITIES FOR 'FREEWHEELING CHATS' WITH STUDENTS

by the Centre to counter the anger and criticism it faced on social media during and after recent protests over paper leaks led by the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP).

The PM has been vocal about using social media platforms to disseminate government plans and programmes, to forge a direct link between the electorate and elected representatives and to shape the narrative. In recent meetings with the Bharatiya Janata Party-led National Democratic Alliance lawmakers, he had reiterated the need to improve social media outreach.

According to a person privy to the details, the ministers had

been informed in July that their social media engagement would be assessed. "This was like a SWOT analysis of their presence on four platforms, and how they compared to some popular leaders and public figures... no rankings were publicly disclosed," said the person quoted above.

The person said the engagement was assessed based on daily posts and the traction they received. "The ministers were asked to improve and increase their social media engagement through newer platforms and more meaningful interactions," said the person quoted above.

The Prime Minister, who has among the highest followers on platforms such as X, recently became more active on Instagram, sharing reels with Gen Z and Gen Alpha users.

The BJP too has begun to calibrate its social media outreach. While a new team headed by Deepak Mhaskey has been announced to head the social media cell, the party has also directed its members to reach out to youth.

{ CABINET DECISIONS }

4 multitasking projects across 8 distts approved

Neha LM Tripathi and Soumya Chatterjee

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NEW DELHI: The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA), chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, on Wednesday approved four multi-tracking projects of the Ministry of Railways costing around ₹9,450 crore, adding about 410 km to the existing network across West Bengal, Odisha, Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh.

The projects include a 173-km fourth line between Kharagpur in West Bengal and Bhadrak (Ranital) in Odisha, a 75-km fourth line between Bhadrak and Haridaspur, a 90-km third and fourth line between Gummidipundi and Gudur, and a 72-km third and fourth line between Cuttack and Paradeep (Badabandha). The projects will cover eight districts and are scheduled for completion by 2030-31.

"The increased line capacity will significantly enhance mobility, resulting in improved opera-

tional efficiency and service reliability for Indian Railways. These proposals are poised to streamline operations and alleviate congestion," the government's statement read.

The projects, planned under the PM Gati Shakti National Master Plan, are expected to improve connectivity to around 6,448 villages with a population of about 60 lakh. These projects will also improve access to several tourist destinations.

₹3,590-crore highway project in Bihar gets nod
The cabinet also approved ₹3,590.73 crore for upgrading the Muzaffarpur-Sitamarhi-Sonbarsa section of NH-22 in Bihar to four lanes under the Hybrid Annuity Model (HAM). The 30-month project will strengthen connectivity to the Nepal border and include seven major bridges, three road overbridges and six underpasses, including a 340-metre bridge over the Bagmati river, Union minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said.

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1 The really-rich have seen the lowest increase in spending after reforms
India's first income survey in the wake of the 2019-20 budget...

Category	Top 1%	Top 10%	Top 10%	All classes
Food	10.7	10.5	10.6	11.2
Non-food	11.3	14.6	15.9	21.6

2 Inequality seems to have fallen even within the really rich
The gap between the rich and the poor...

Category	Top 1%	Top 10%	Top 10%	All classes
Food	0.28	0.15	0.24	0.23
Non-food	0.17	0.23	0.18	0.33



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5 Bangladeshis among nine dead in Kolkata hotel blaze

Tanmay Chatterjee and Joydeep Thakur
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KOLKATA: Five Bangladeshi nationals, including a two-year-and-eight-month-old boy, a Jharkhand resident and a Siliguri resident were among nine people killed after a fire broke out at a hotel on the second floor of a five-storey building on Mirza Ghalib Street in central Kolkata around 2am on Wednesday, city police and Kolkata's Bangladesh deputy high commission officials said.

A five-member special investigation team (SIT) has been formed to probe the fire and alleged lapses in fire-safety measures.

The blaze broke out at Shikha Inn, one of several small hotels operating from the building at 15H Mirza Ghalib Street. Four fire tenders reached the spot and brought the fire under control in about two hours, officials said.

The building is around 50 metres from the West Bengal Fire and Emergency Services head-quarters and within about 500 metres of the Kolkata Municipal Corporation.

Chief minister Svendud Adhikari said the fire highlighted alleged failures in enforcing safety norms. "This tragedy is a grim reminder of the legacy of negligence left behind by the previous regime," he wrote on X.

"A five-member Special Investigation Team (SIT) has been formed to conduct a comprehensive inquiry into this incident," the CM added.

The five Bangladeshi victims were identified as Debashish Dutta, 39, a journalist from Kushtia; his wife Afsana Sharmin, 27; their two-year-and-eight-month-old son Swarnashish Dutta; Afsana's father Md Akram Ali, 74; and Ahmed Babu (37) from Dhaka, deputy high commissioner of Bangladesh in Kolkata, Mohammad Khaled said.

Bangladesh deputy high commission officials said Dutta had travelled to Bengaluru for medical treatment. The family checked into the Kolkata hotel on Tuesday after returning from Bengaluru and was scheduled to return to Bangladesh on Wednesday.

"Two bodies remained uniden-

tified till Wednesday evening," deputy commissioner of police (central division) Prawn Prakash said.

Firefighters said thick smoke quickly engulfed the third floor cutting off access to the only staircase. "We rescued more than 60 persons who were unhurt but at least nine people were found unconscious. They were rushed to hospital," a fire brigade officer said.

The officer added, "We suspect a short circuit caused the fire. We can confirm only after the forensic analysis."

Md Ujjwal, a 49-year-old businessman from Khulna in Bangladesh staying at Hotel Adrita on the same floor, said, "With the fire blocking access to the only staircase, I locked myself inside the room and broke a plank near the air-conditioner to allow fresh air in. About an hour later, the fire brigade rescued me," he said.

Amirul Hossain, a guest at the hotel, said, "There was no fire alarm, no fire exit, and no fire-fighting system. It was a miracle that we managed to escape."

State fire and emergency services minister Kaushik Chowdhury said, "In each of the floors there were at least four to five hotels. The rooms in these hotels were small and most of them didn't have any window or ventilation. There was hardly any fire-alarm or fire-fighting system."

Locals said the buildings at 15F, 15G and 15H Mirza Ghalib Street were originally residential but were gradually converted into commercial spaces.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi condoled the deaths and shared a post on X: "Extremely pained to learn about the loss of lives due to a fire mishap in Kolkata. My condolences to those who have lost their loved ones in this tragedy."

Minister Agnimitra Paul, who visited the site, said, "How were these hotels running? How did they get the trade license, fire license and power connection?," Paul told the reporters.

Former minister Firhad Hakim accused the government of politicising the tragedy. "This is politics. During our tenure so many people died in devastating fires in Kolkata but we never blamed the erstwhile Left Front government."

Timeline of the incident

1:30 am-2 am: Fire breaks out at Shikha Inn on the second floor of a five-storey building on Mirza Ghalib Street
2 am: Guests wake up to screams and shouts as thick smoke engulfs the third floor, cutting off access to the only staircase
2:10 am: Four fire tenders reach the spot and begin rescue operations. Firefighters rescue more than 60 people over the next two hours.
4 am: Fire is brought under control
4 pm: Nine people are confirmed dead, including five Bangladeshis



national, a Jharkhand resident and a Siliguri resident. Two bodies remain unidentified
5 pm: A five-member SIT is formed to probe the fire and alleged lapses in fire-safety arrangements

B'deshi journalist, kin had come for treatment

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KOLKATA: A Bangladeshi journalist, his wife, their young son and his father-in-law were among nine people killed in the fire at Hotel Shikha Inn in central Kolkata on Wednesday. The family had come to India for medical treatment and was scheduled to return to Bangladesh the same day.

At Aruapara in Bangladesh's Kushtia, Swapna Dutta, 62, has been inconsolable since learning that her son Debashish Dutta, 39, daughter-in-law Afsana Sharmin, 27, and two-year-and-eight-month-old grandson Swarnashish Dutta, had died. Their six-year-old daughter had stayed back with her grandparents in Kushtia.

"I last spoke to my son around 9:45 pm on Tuesday. They had done some shopping and my son said they would be back home on Wednesday. How will I raise my granddaughter now?" Swapna told reporters.

The family, including Sharmin's father Akram Ali, 74, travelled to India on August 3 for treatment. After spending two days in Kolkata, they went to Bengaluru for Sharmin's and Sharmashish's

treatment and returned to Kolkata before checking into Shikha Inn on Monday.

The Bangladesh deputy high commission said five of the nine victims were Bangladeshi nationals. Four were from Kushtia and belonged to the same family. The fifth victim was Babu Ahmed, 37, from Aminabazar in Dhaka.

The New Market area, including Mirza Ghalib Street, Marquis Street and Sudder Street, has several budget hotels popular with Bangladeshi visitors. Room tariffs can start at around ₹500.

"I am a tourist from Dhaka... This area offers cheap hotels and is also centrally located. The buses which come from Dhaka stops at Esplanade, which is close by. Also, the shopping area is nearby. Hence this New Market area is a favourite spot for us Bangladeshis who come to Kolkata," said Md Mushfiqur Rahaman, 42, from Khulna.

India resumed normal tourist visa services for Bangladeshis in June 2026 after restrictions imposed following political unrest in 2024. A total of 1.6 million Bangladeshis visited India in 2023, with 60% travelling for tourism and 30% for medical treatment.

SHAH TO VISIT WB FROM FRIDAY TO REVIEW BORDER SECURITY STEPS

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NEW DELHI: Union home minister Amit Shah is set to visit West Bengal on Friday and Saturday during which he will hold review meetings related to the India-Nepal and India-Bangladesh border security, officials aware of the matter said.

The meeting will be held in Siliguri, which shares border with Nepal, Bangladesh and Bhutan.

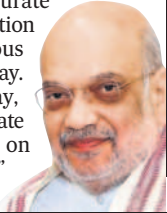
Shah is directly flying to West Bengal from his meeting in Mahabalipuram where he will chair the 31st meeting of the Southern Zonal Council on Thursday.

Ahead of Shah's visit, top police officers from West Bengal including police chief Siddhant Nath Gupta have reached Siliguri and are reviewing the arrangements.

The West Bengal police has prepared an update of the developments in the last 100 days and an exhibition on the complete implementation of the three criminal laws in the state.

"The SSB and the BSF will share updates on the border security," an official said.

A second officer said, "The HM will inaugurate and lay foundation stone for various projects on Friday. Later in the day, he will inaugurate the exhibition on the three laws."



Won't allow woman officer to be humiliated: SC to govt

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Wednesday told the Centre to review its "arbitrary denial" of permanent commission to a woman coast guard officer within two weeks, observing that the government's inaction to provide for gender-friendly infrastructure cannot be a ground to "humiliate a meritorious officer".

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant, justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana was hearing a petition filed by commandant Priyanka Tyagi, who joined as a short service appointment (SSA) officer in 2009.

"We will not allow an officer to be humiliated in this manner. Show some sportsmanship. She is an excellent officer. We will give you two weeks. Consider in the meantime or else we will pass an order," the bench said.

Tyagi completed 17 years in service after the apex court in April 2024 permitted her to continue beyond the 14-year service stipulation under short service commission (SSC).

Attorney General R Venkataramani, representing the Centre, told the court that a major policy decision taken last month now permits permanent commission for women officers.

"Can you deny permanent commission only on the ground that you do not have a policy?" the bench asked the top law offi-

GOVT HAS BEEN ASKED TO REVIEW 'ARBITRARY DENIAL' OF PERMANENT COMMISSION TO A WOMAN COAST GUARD OFFICER

cer. "She has continuously been serving with you for so many years. Since 2021, she has been applying and even recommended by her superior officers. She is excellent on merit and till today, you are not coming forward with an offer of permanent commission for her."

Venkataramani said the option is not foreclosed as she can apply under the new policy. "I am also vocal about gender justice as our heart is no different from yours when it comes to these issues. But she had a choice to apply for permanent commission or SSA when she joined," he said.

"What about men?" the court asked. "Don't you have permanent commission for men? Let us not go into this hyper technical objection that she did not apply as it won't work. What else can be the reason to deny women other than the fact that you have infrastructure only for men...it is a case of arbitrary denial," the bench added.

Denying that it was a gender-related issue, the AG added that the Coast Guard has its own limi-

tations and it is important for the court to take into account the history and peculiarities of Coast Guard.

Advocate Siddhant Sharma, appearing for Tyagi, told the court that if she applies afresh under the new policy, she will be rejected. The policy, he pointed out, requires officers to undertake several tests which are meant to be taken by officers after the eighth year of SSA. Tyagi has completed 13 months of flying training to qualify as a navigator and has the highest-flying hours as per her seniority, about 4,500 hours on the Dornier Aircraft, he said. She was selected twice to participate in international exercise as a detachment commander and was part of the first ever all-women crew deployed in the Eastern Region for Maritime Patrolling, Sharma added.

The court told the attorney general: "Her prayer may not be in sync with your policy but she has been promoted and even recommended for permanent commission by her superiors. Instead of asking her to apply afresh, just absorb her. Do these facts not merit a more enlarged consideration by you?"

Tyagi joined as assistant commandant in December 2009, just weeks after the Assistant Commandant Woman (General Duty) Short Service Recruitment Rules were published, denying women officers the option to change over to permanent entry scheme.

Boss's stern behaviour not suicide abetment: SC

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has held that ordinary administrative directions, disciplinary supervision, adverse remarks on an official's performance, even stern behaviour by a superior, however unpleasant they may have been perceived by the deceased, cannot by themselves be elevated to the offence of abetment of suicide under the penal law.

A bench of justices Satish Chandra Sharma and N Kotiswar Singh said that there must be additional material demonstrating a conscious intention to drive a subordinate to commit suicide.

THE COURT SAID THAT CRIMINAL LIABILITY UNDER SECTION 306 OF IPC CANNOT REST UPON TRAGEDY OF THE OUTCOME

"Criminal liability under Section 306 of the IPC (abetment to suicide) cannot rest upon the tragedy of the outcome alone; it must be founded upon the statutory ingredients of Section 306, which are absent in the present case," said the bench while discharging a senior forest officer accused of abetting the suicide of a woman

forest range officer.

The judgment, released earlier this week, came in an appeal filed by Vinod Shivakumar, then deputy conservator of forests, against the Bombay High Court's refusal to interfere with criminal proceedings against him. The Supreme Court set aside the high court and trial court orders and discharged Shivakumar from the case.

The case arose from the suicide on March 25, 2021, of a forest range officer posted in the Harisar Range in Maharashtra. She shot herself with her official weapon and left behind three suicide notes addressed to the additional principal chief conservator of forests and area director, her mother and her

husband. The notes specifically blamed Shivakumar for her death.

The prosecution alleged that Shivakumar had subjected her to mental harassment and made her undertake field duties. The allegations also included an incident in March 2020 concerning removal of an encroachment forcing her to trek in the forest despite her pregnancy, which she alleged resulted in a miscarriage. The woman officer's suicide note alleged that Shivakumar abused and humiliated her in the presence of staff.

The Supreme Court, however, said that abetment requires direct or indirect instigation in close proximity to the suicide and clear mens rea to abet its commission.

ED RAIDS JAUHAR VARSITY, 9 OTHER SITES IN MONEY LAUNDERING CASE

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LUCKNOW: The Lucknow unit of the Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Wednesday conducted simultaneous searches at 10 premises in Rampur, Saharanpur and Delhi as part of its money-laundering investigation into the Maulana Mohammad Ali Jauhar Trust and Mohammad Ali Jauhar University founded by jailed senior Samajwadi Party leader Azam Khan in Rampur, senior officials said.

According to officials, the ED investigation centres on the alleged diversion of funds generated through government contracts and their subsequent routing towards the trust and university.

The agency is trying to establish the complete money trail and identify the individuals and companies through which the alleged funds were routed to the trust or university, officials said.

The role of contractors, their associates and the chartered accountant is also being examined, officials said.

According to officials, the searches, carried out by the ED's Lucknow zonal office under Section 17 of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), began Wednesday morning. An ED team comprising around 15 officials reached the Jauhar University in Rampur at around 7am and began examining documents and other records. More than 100 police personnel were deployed outside the campus as part of the security arrangements. Classes, however, continued at the university.

The premises searched included those linked to a chartered accountant in Saharanpur, a private firm in Rampur (a partner of Jauhar Associates) in Jasola-Jamia Nagar, Delhi, and another private limited firm and its director in Rampur. The premises of a private person on Jail Road in Rampur were also searched, the officials said.

Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav alleged that the raids targeted those who established universities to appease a section of BJP supporters.

"BJP members and their associates, who have shut down schools, are orchestrating ED raids against those who established universities to appease the remaining 1-2% of their supporters who harbour narrow, communal mindsets," he said in a statement.

Immoral Traffic Act sections do not apply to customers, rules high court

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PRAYAGRAJ: The Allahabad high court has ruled that a man who visits a brothel as a customer cannot be prosecuted under Sections 3, 4, 5 and 7 of the Immoral Traffic (Prevention) Act, 1956, merely for paying money for personal gratification.

Justice Gautam Chowdhary, in an order dated August 11, observed that paying money to satisfy personal lust does not amount to procurement for the "purpose of prostitution" as defined under the Act, which requires commercial exploitation. "If a person visits a brothel as a customer, then at the most, he may be procuring a prostitute to satisfy his personal lust, but not for the 'purpose of prostitution' as defined under the Act

'PAYING MONEY TO SATISFY PERSONAL LUST IS NOT PROCUREMENT FOR THE PURPOSE OF PROSTITUTION'

(which requires commercial exploitation). Therefore, a customer who pays money for gratification cannot be prosecuted under Section 3, 4, 5, or 7 of the Act," the court said.

With this observation, the court allowed the petition filed by a man named Nitin and quashed the charge sheet and criminal proceedings against the petitioner, who was among 16 people apprehended during a police raid on a house in Ghaziabad on December 31, 2023.

Nitin was charged under Sections 3, 4, 5, and 7 of the ITPA, and the high court found these charges legally unsustainable for a customer as they were related to running and management of a brothel.

The court said that a customer cannot be said to be keeping or managing or acting or assisting in the keeping or management of a brothel because he simply comes and pays money to get a woman to satisfy his lust.

The court further observed, "Perusal of the record shows that the applicant was merely a customer who came to satisfy his personal lust after paying the money and not for the purpose of prostitution; therefore, the provisions of Sections 3, 4, 5, 7 of the Immoral Traffic (Prevention) Act, 1956, are not attracted against the applicant."

Leh and Kargil bodies submit non-negotiable points to MHA officials

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SRINAGAR: The leaders from Ladakh held fresh round of talks with the Union home ministry officials on Wednesday and handed a list of "non-negotiable" demands, including constitutional safeguards for Ladakh, officials aware of the matter said.

Prominent leaders of the Leh Apex Body and the Kargil Development Council attended the meeting, they said.

"The meeting between the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA), Leh Apex Body (LAB), and the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) officials has concluded," said Sajad Kargili, a member of the Kargil Democratic Alliance, who attended the meeting.

"We submitted our Important and non-negotiable points to the government, clearly outlining our key demands and constitutional safeguards for Ladakh. We also submitted a resolution demanding the unconditional withdrawal of all cases against those affected by the September 24 violent

clashes, along with dignified and adequate compensation for the victims and their families," he said.

The MHA did not issue a statement on the negotiations on Wednesday.

The Union Territory of Ladakh was created on August 5, 2019, after the Centre abrogated Article 370, which had bestowed special status on Jammu and Kashmir, and split the erstwhile state into two Union territories — Jammu and Kashmir with a legislative assembly, and Ladakh without one.

The Ladakh leaders have been protesting since then to press their demands.

In 2023, the Union home ministry formed a high-powered committee under minister of state for home Nityanand Rai to discuss ways to protect Ladakh's unique culture and language, given its location and strategic importance.

Last month, Ladakh LG VK Saxena announced that the UT will have Autonomous Hill Councils in all seven districts, including the five newly established ones.

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SC-NTA

submitted its recommendations in October 2024. HT reported in late July that only 57 of the 101 recommendations of the Radhakrishnan committee were fully recommended and another 10 partially. One of the most significant of these recommendations, the restructuring of NTA, was implemented only in the third week of July, following the 2026 NEET paper leak, which forced a retest. The controversy eventually claimed the head of then education minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

The court directed the secretary concerned to file an affidavit within three weeks, detailing the steps taken to implement the Radhakrishnan committee's recommendations as reflected and nuanced by the Nilekani committee, along with indicative timelines.

The order said its concern was the "institutionalisation of National Testing Agency with all necessary infrastructure, manpower and other technological capabilities."

The court's intervention came as the Centre explained in detail the elaborate security measures currently employed by the NTA to prevent question-paper leaks, including multiple layers of question-paper selection, sealed transportation, GPS tracking, CCTV surveillance, police escort and one-time-use boxes that have to be physically broken open before the examination.

But the bench said such measures were already part of the examination systems examined by the Radhakrishnan committee and the real concern was whether these safeguards could survive changes in personnel and evolve into a permanent institutional processes.

"All this was already under the purview of the Radhakrishnan committee," observed the bench, pointing out that the court had gone through the systems being developed over a period of time. It added that the committee had correctly identified the problem as systemic, requiring institutionalisation.

"This process on paper, everything is good. But then one exam happens and by the time the second exam happens, it is a new picture altogether," said the bench, adding that it wanted to know what the NTA actually looked like as an institution -- how many officers it had, where its office was situated, how

Supreme Court seeks details of Nilekani task force's mandate

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court bench hearing the NEET paper leak case on Wednesday sought clarity on the role of the Nandan Nilekani-led task force, which was constituted last month to overhaul India's examination system.

While the K Radhakrishnan committee (set up in 2024) had focused substantially on NEET and strengthening the NTA, the Nilekani panel has a wider mandate covering the country's examination ecosystem and the statutory framework of the NTA. Its recommendations are aimed at making the examination system "robust, secure, transparent, trustworthy and future-ready", with emphasis on technologies such as AI and blockchain.

The court asked the Centre to place on record whether the Nilekani panel had modified or "nuanced" the recommendations of the Radhakrishnan committee.

much staff and security it had and what infrastructure had been created.

In addition to the recent paper leak, NTA has also been left red-faced by errors in some papers, their most recent being those in UGC-NET discovered Sunday.

On Monday, reacting to the Sunday incident, education ministry officials said NTA has fired at least 50 staff and embarked on the process of filling 10 new senior positions including Chief Technology Officer, General Manager (Test Security), and GM (R&D and Psychometrics).

The Supreme Court's observations on Wednesday assume significance against the backdrop of recurring NEET-UG paper leaks and the court's earlier concerns that merely shifting an examination online would not by itself eliminate the possibility of question-paper breaches.

Solicitor general Tushar Mehta told the court that the Centre had accepted the Radhakrishnan committee's recom-

mendations "in toto" and that steps were being taken to implement them.

Mehta added that advertisements had been issued for several positions, including a technology officer, chief finance officer and general managers.

The bench, however, sought details of whether the newly sanctioned senior positions had actually been filled and whether the NTA had a separate physical establishment and the requisite manpower.

The court drew a comparison with the Union Public Service Commission, saying that an institution which conducts examinations regularly develops institutional memory and expertise over time.

"Experienced persons get transferred. Then the whole experience goes. It must flow down to the next level and the next level so that they could pick up from the seniors. Institutional memory does not depend on individuals," it remarked.

The bench also asked whether the NTA had a dedicated department and full-time officer for digital infrastructure, besides adequate testing infrastructure and research and development capabilities.

The Centre informed the court that the NTA was setting up its own technology team with support from the National Informatics Centre and was onboarding professional teams as well as developing indigenous artificial intelligence models for translation of question papers.

Mehta said that the NTA's question bank of 500 questions was translated into 13 languages, but the government was not relying on AI for the translation at present and was using human translators. "There was a breach and the people who were involved are arrested," he said.

The bench also raised concerns over data security, asking whether the NTA had a sovereign database to store examination data and what sovereign software was being developed for the purpose. The court said security of question papers and storage of examination data required dedicated infrastructure and a database that was ready for use.

Printed papers are jumbled, packed in tamper-proof boxes with unique identifiers, and placed in one-time-use iron trunks. Two sets are transported in GPS-tracked vehicles to separate bank strong rooms. On the exam day, the Director General informs the city coordinator which trunk to use; it is moved under police protection and video surveillance to centres. The final packet is opened shortly before the test in the presence of two students, with the process recorded for future

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

reference.

The bench, however, said the issue was not whether the procedures were elaborate but whether the NTA had the institutional capacity to continuously upgrade and enforce them. "You have to train and prepare the personnel for times to come, not just for one examination," the bench said, stressing the need for candidate-friendly arrangements, grievance mechanisms and strengthening of the agency's physical and intellectual capacity.

The petitions have been filed by the United Doctors Front, Federation of All India Medical Associations and others seeking restructuring of the NTA and a stronger oversight mechanism to prevent recurring question-paper leaks.

Centre details elaborate question-paper security
The Solicitor General outlined the NTA's multi-layered process for preparing and transporting question papers to prevent leaks.

A large question bank is first created by multiple moderators, after which a second set of moderators prepares four papers; the Director General then selects two, ensuring no single person knows the final paper. These are sent in sealed covers to printing presses under CCTV and CISF security, with the digital code to open the covers provided only upon arrival. The presses are closed to outsiders and the entire operation is video-recorded.

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FUEL PUMP EXPLOSION
Singh and have contacted the dealer for an enquiry into the cause of the blast.

HT reached out to Aadhya Energies and Himanshu Singh for comment, but did not receive a response.

Delhi chief minister Rekha Gupta expressed her condolences and called the incident "deeply unfortunate".

The incident took place around 3.20pm, said bystanders and petrol pump staff.

Eyewitnesses said four or five trucks were at the pump when the blast shook the neighbourhood. Dharmendra Singh, a truck driver, said the explosion flung the staffer who was filling the vehicle that exploded into a corner.

"We all got scared, left our vehicles and ran. The staffers inside also fled. Nobody came back," said Singh.

The explosion charred two trucks, a Maruti Eeco Van, a two-wheeler and equipment at the pump.

Manish and Sunny were taken to Sanjay Gandhi Hospital, where they were declared

dead, while Brahmjeet died at Jeevan Jyoti Hospital.

Delhi's deputy commissioner of police (outer) Vikram Singh said they received a call reporting the incident around 3.20pm.

"Eyewitnesses said many were injured. We rushed to the spot and found six injured people, three of whom died. The injured persons were admitted at CD Global Hospital in Mundka," said Singh.

A Delhi Fire Services (DFS) spokesperson said six tenders were sent in for the rescue, which was complicated by potential gas leaks.

"Since there was a leakage, there was some risk in the rescue...The station was evacuated and only police and DFS personnel were allowed. Three of the six persons, who were standing near the truck, sustained severe injuries and were taken to the hospital by public persons and PCR vans," said the spokesperson.

Senior Delhi Police officers said an IGL team also inspected the spot to ascertain the cause of the leak.

"We are not sure if the leak is from the gas tank or from the pipe at the station. A case of negligence will be lodged. We are just trying to find out the sequence of events. The station is licensed and is being operated by a dealer. We will question him as well," an officer said.

Families allege victims left for 30 minutes without help

Manish and Sunny's families said they were only the earners in their households. Manish had been working at the station for nearly three years.

His uncle, Vijay Prasad, said: "I was in Narela for some work. I received a call around 3.45pm that Manish was injured. I called my brother, nephews and sons to rush to Tikri Kalan. They reached around 4.30pm and Manish was still lying in a corner. All the other staffers had fled."

"DFS and police were taking time to help the injured. He lay there for more than 30 minutes without any help. A PCR van later came and took him to the hospital. Manish has a five-month-old baby. Who will take care of the family now?"

Police and DFS both said they reached within 15 to 20 minutes of the call. Police, however, added that they were verifying the family's allegations.

His friend, Kumar, who goes by a single name, told HT that Manish raised concerns about leaks at the pump weeks ago.

"Manish had told me there was a leakage in the pipes around 20 days ago. The station owner gave all the workers two days' leave after they flagged the issues. They were later asked to join but we don't know if the pipes were fixed or not," he said.

Aadhya Energies did not respond to requests for comment.

"Manish got married two years back. His wife is in shock. He was taking care of his elderly parents and baby. I saw his body and almost fainted..." he added.

Sunny's family said his elder brother died in an accident a few years ago.

His cousin, Balraj Singh, said: "He was working there for two or three years. His elder brother used to work at a petrol station but died in a road accident a few years back. Sunny was taking care of his parents and his brother's two children. We wanted him to get married and start his own family. I got a call at 4pm about the accident. By the time I reached, he was taken to the hospital and had died."

Balraj also said Sunny had mentioned that workers flagged the leaks in the pumps with the owners.

Brahmjeet's nephew Aaditya Singh said both his paternal uncles work at the station.

"We received a call around 3.30pm about the blast. There was no police or ambulance here. Both my uncles were lying, covered in blood. We rushed them to Jeevan Jyoti Hospital where my uncle died. My older uncle is undergoing treatment. He suffered injuries to his waist and back. Brahmjeet was married and has two children. He had been working here for two years but nobody helped him," he said.

Chief minister Gupta con- doled the incident.

"The loss of lives in the tragic incident at Tikri Kalan is deeply unfortunate," her office said in a post on X.

"Chief Minister Smt. Rekha Gupta has conveyed her condolences to the bereaved families. Officials have been directed to ensure all necessary assistance and the best possible medical care for the injured to aid their speedy recovery. Government teams are on the spot and the situation is being closely monitored," it added.

FOREIGNER DIES IN RPF CUSTODY AT SURAT RLY STATION

AHMEDABAD: A foreign national died during questioning at an RPF post at Surat railway station on the night of August 17 after he was detained following an altercation with co-passengers aboard the Golden Temple Express, officials said on Wednesday.

The unidentified man, believed to be in his 40s, was travelling in a general coach from Mumbai to Delhi. According to police, after the train left Vapi station, he got into an argument with passengers over standing near the coach door. The quarrel turned physical and he allegedly picked up a fire extinguisher and assaulted passengers with it.

MANIPUR SHUTS EDU INSTITUTIONS AMID UNREST

IMPHAL: The Manipur government on Wednesday ordered the closure of all educational institutions across the state from August 20 to 23 in view of the prevailing law and order situation, according to an official order. Earlier in the day, normal life remained paralysed across several valley districts in Manipur as the 48-hour shutdown called by a Meitei group against the Census until an NRC is done, entered its last day. The organisation announced a boycott of all government institutions starting Thursday as part of its stir.

ARREST WARRANT ORDERED AGAINST MAHUA MOITRA

KOLKATA: A Nadia court in West Bengal on Wednesday ordered the issuance of an arrest warrant against Krishnanagar MP Mahua Moitra for not appearing in an alleged hate speech case filed against her in June, lawyers who attended the hearing said.

"The judge observed on Wednesday that the MP showed a 'lackadaisical approach' to complying with the court's order," a lawyer said, on condition of anonymity. The court directed that the warrant be issued and an execution report be placed before the court on August 28.

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OPINION

The
Hindu Times
ESTABLISHED IN 1924

{ OUR TAKE }

Broken trust in temple fraud

Systemic lapses flagged by the SIT probing the siphoning of Ram Temple donations cast a shadow on the competence of temple trustees

A report from the special investigation team (SIT) exonerating two prominent former functionaries of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust might bring relief to the individuals but the systemic lapses flagged by the probe are a matter of grave concern and raise questions about the competence of the people managing one of India's most important shrines.

The report by the SIT — one of two looking into allegations of irregularities in the Ram Temple donation collections — found gross lapses in the trust's functioning, an absence of adequate checks or professional financial management and inadequate supervision at multiple levels. Damningly, the SIT found there was no dedicated finance and audit cell, no standard operating procedure for collection agents and inadequate reconciliation between donation receipts issued and money deposited. Clearly, even the basics of fiduciary responsibility were thrown to the wind, creating an opaque system where ad-hoc decisions and personal favours masqueraded as systems and processes, making the whole operation vulnerable to dubious actors.

The SIT named Ram Shankar Yadav, an aide to former trust general secretary Champat Rai, as the mastermind and blamed the eight men who have already been arrested. The report detailed specific bank accounts and shell entities allegedly used to layer the transactions and noted that some of the money was used to buy agricultural land and commercial plots. But most of these men were small-time players whose hires were overseen by trust members — some of them were even related to former trust members. How could they erect such a sophisticated operation without anyone noticing? Were the trust elders asleep at the wheel? Why didn't they declare any conflict-of-interest while hiring people they knew? Why wasn't professional management brought in at the beginning? It is not enough to just admit that mistakes were made, accountability must be fixed.

This newspaper has noted before that any scandal connected to the Ram Temple insults millions of people whose faith is tied to the shrine. It is good if no trust member was personally involved in the misappropriation but they cannot evade culpability for systemic lapses. The SIT report should pave the way for deeper investigation and introspection, not be used as a fig leaf to elide responsibility. The reforms currently underway in the trust should be sped up. And the second SIT set up by the Supreme Court should strive to fix accountability and ensure such sordid saga is never repeated.

Death penalty by any method is still death

A grave looking man — always a man — in judicial robes, with or without the peruke, pronounces “to be hanged till death” and breaks the nib of his pen after signing the relevant papers awarding capital punishment to the defendant. In Hindi cinema of a certain vintage, this was an oft repeated scene, establishing either the injustice meted out to the protagonist or fate catching up with his nemesis at last. Scriptwriters, understandably, leaned heavily on the emotion capital punishment evokes in the masses. Whether cinematic tropes were mirroring jurisprudence, or vice-versa, is actually irrelevant. What matters is that discussions on the legitimacy of capital punishment in India are as old as the Constitution. The latest debate, oddly, is only on the method of execution.

Per Section 393(5) of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), executions are carried out by hanging despite the Law Commission's recommendation in 2015 that more advanced methods should be adopted. The Supreme Court (SC) has now rejected a petition challenging the constitutional validity of hanging on the grounds that it violates the right to a dignified death protected under Article 21. The SC maintained that the process causes no greater pain than any other known method and avoids “barbarity, torture and degradation”. Interestingly, the SC keeps the issue open, not precluding further government deliberation and the evolution of constitutionality. This is exactly where the punishment must take precedence over the method. By retaining the capital punishment even in the decolonised doctrine of dispensing justice, India has stuck to a relic that even the UK shed in 1965. Since India has notably progressive laws, the death penalty sticks out as a badly produced masala film from the 1980s screening at an arthouse cinema retrospective.

Sanction-proofing India's interests and autonomy

India needs a permanent Economic Security and Sanctions Office rather than a committee that meets intermittently

Recently, by 86 votes to 11, the US Senate passed a bill that could turn a barrel of crude oil bought from Russia into tariffs on Indian exports wholly unrelated to oil. The bill, however, preserved waivers for limited imports of Russian enriched uranium. Revenue from Russian energy exports helps Moscow sustain the war in Ukraine. That is a serious case for action. The harder question is who is punished, who gets waivers, and, most importantly, who decides.

The bill passed by the Senate is not yet law. If enacted, it would allow additional tariffs of up to 100% on goods exported to the US by countries that continue buying Russian oil or gas and rank among the five largest buyers, or among the five leading facilitators of Russian oil sanctions evasion. India is not named, but the scale of its Russian crude purchases places it within the formula. The trigger is oil. The leverage is Indian exports to America, from machinery and electronics to gems, jewellery and textiles. The bill also lets the President waive any duty in the US national interest.

India now has to reckon with powers that can turn economic dependence into political leverage. Washing-

ton reaches trade transactions through the dollar payment system and the American market. Brussels can restrict market access and maritime services. Beijing controls some critical industrial inputs. Each can use what others depend on to demand compliance and then decide who gets a waiver. India needs an institutional answer to that power, beyond diplomatic objections.

The US still imports 20-25% of its enriched uranium from Russia. A 2024 American law bans imports of Russian low enriched uranium but permits limited imports under individual waivers through 2027 if no viable alternative exists or the US national interest requires it. The energy department has granted Centrus, an American nuclear fuel supplier, a waiver covering deliveries already agreed to with US customers. This is Washington admitting that reactors, contracts, and fuel cycles do not rearrange themselves because the US Congress wants to uphold a principle. India can change crude suppliers more readily, though not painlessly and not overnight. The waiver thus concedes what sanctions rhetoric leaves out: Energy systems cannot be reordered on command.

In July 2025, the EU placed Nayara on its assets-freeze list. The Indian refinery is 49%-owned by Rosneft, Russia's State-controlled oil company. Inclusion in the list barred people and companies subject to EU law from providing Nayara with funds or

other economic resources. The EU's sanctions on Nayara were effected through contracts as service providers and shipowners pulled back.

Measures targeting Russian petroleum work differently. Under the same package of measures that included sanctions on Nayara, the EU barred, from January 2026, imports of specified petroleum products refined from Russian crude in third countries. In March 2026, the US issued a temporary waiver (through General License 133) for the delivery



Syed Akbaruddin

and unloading in India of Russian oil already at sea. This license included necessary insurance and maritime services. A company listed for business restrictions, an import ban, and a temporary licence do not have the same legal effect. Treating all three as sanctions on India leads to the wrong response. It blurs who is acting, what rule they are relying on, and where India has room to push back.

China shows how the control of an indispensable input can become leverage. In two rounds earlier this year, it barred exports of goods with both civilian and military uses to 40 Japanese entities that Beijing linked to military activity and placed 40 more under tighter licensing. It imposed similar restrictions on 10 American companies. India depends on China for most of its imported permanent magnets. For Indian manufacturers, a licence issued or withheld in Beijing can determine whether a production line in Chennai is able to run



Sanctions can serve legitimate security purposes. But India should challenge coercion that travels far beyond the country imposing it. REUTERS

the next month or not.

India's longstanding position is that it implements UN sanctions but does not subscribe to unilateral measures imposed by individual States. This protects a vital legal principle, but it is no longer enough.

Sanctions can serve legitimate security purposes. India should instead challenge coercion that travels far beyond the country imposing it — often with inadequate notice, opaque evidence and weak review — especially when that country protects its own necessities through exemptions. If energy dependence is a reason for waivers in one country, it cannot automatically become evidence of bad faith in another.

India needs a permanent Economic Security and Sanctions Office. It must be a standing unit linking foreign policy, finance, trade, law, the RBI, petroleum, atomic energy, defence and technology rather than a committee that meets intermittently. Firms need to know what Indian law requires, which foreign rules reach their transactions, and when cau-

tious banks or suppliers are imposing restrictions required by neither Indian nor foreign law. The office should identify where alternative suppliers or lawful payment routes are needed, explain exemptions and coordinate challenges before a payment fails, a cargo is stranded or a customer walks away.

India cannot stop powerful States from using the chokepoints they control. It can contest the terms on which that power is used and insist that its own needs are accounted for. That contest over strategic autonomy will be fought in waiver clauses, licence schedules and bank compliance rooms, not only in speeches about sovereignty. If India's necessities never qualify as necessities, strategic autonomy will shrink from a doctrine into an application for somebody else's permission.

Syed Akbaruddin served as India's permanent representative to the United Nations in New York and is currently dean, Kautilya School of Public Policy. The views expressed are personal

Need to root public health education in Indian realities

The student protests focused the nation on medical education. But its poorer cousins — dental, nursing, or public health education — don't seem to be registering on the policy radar. Their problems go beyond the traditional challenges that the education sector suffers from — poor quality, lack of teachers and infrastructure. Public health education principally entails the MPH (Master of Public Health) programme with some institutions also offering undergraduate and doctoral programmes.

While clinical medicine is about diagnosing and treating individual patients, public health addresses populations or community health problems. Public health functions broadly include health surveillance, protection, promotion, planning, regulation, services organisation, delivery, and evaluation. Public health also requires a wide gamut of workforce trained in public health nutrition, occupational and environmental health, epidemiology and biostatistics, health administration and management, informatics, social sciences, economics, and policy analysis. Clinical services and public health services are complementary and together improve a nation's health.

Given the wide range of competencies required to deliver comprehensive public health, a diversity in disciplinary backgrounds of students joining the profession is necessary: medicine, allied health sciences, social sciences and law to name a few. The MPH programmes are offered by a wide variety of institutions, from medical colleges to social sciences as well as agriculture universities with each having their own eligibility criteria. At the same time, the expectation is to produce postgraduates with similar exit-level competencies. There is hardly any other professional course that has this wide diversity at the entry level and the challenge to produce a relatively homogenous end-product.

States that have a public health cadre — Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra and Odisha — currently have about one public health specialist per 100,000 population or less. Efforts are on to create a public health management cadre to meet the norm of three per 100,000 population. Even this target pales in front of the current realities in countries such as the US which has about 55 public health professionals per 100,000 population. In India, currently 125 MPH programmes produce about 5,000 postgraduates a year in contrast to the US producing about 17,000.

The basic clinical skills of recording medical history, measuring pulse, auscultation of breaths and heart sounds are universal; what differs across countries is their interpretation. High fever in a patient can mean malaria in a specific season or typhoid or dengue in other places or seasons.

Similarly, basic public health competencies and principles of epidemiology, biostatistics, management, social sciences or communication are universal but contexts and local particularities have a bearing on community behaviours, health systems, programmes or policies. MPH programmes in India are rooted in Western models which may train candidates in the same competencies but miss out real-world Indian contexts. MPH programmes are run as classroom courses that are highly sanitised, an antithesis of both a public health

course and discourse.

The lack of a centralised regulatory body is taking a toll on quality of these courses. Regulation of MPH programmes has fallen between two stools — National Medical Commission (NMC) and University Grants Commission (UGC). Since medical, dental, and AYUSH graduates account for the bulk of MPH candidates, should it be regulated by these councils? At the same time, MPH is not inherently a medical, dental or AYUSH degree. Many non-medical universities regulated by the UGC offer this degree too. Aligning MPH programmes with the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 and the UGC framework which advocates academic flexibility, credit transfer, and multiple entry-exit options is a challenge given that this is a professional course.

Do we have a credible road map for reform? A group of concerned academics (both of us are part of it) have initiated efforts to advocate for corrective measures. The group recently released its report and we summarise its key findings and recommendations here.

First, India needs to expand to a broad-based public health service, beyond mere clinical provision. There is a need to advocate for a specialised public health cadre in all the states and open up career opportunities for trained MPH professionals. In the event of India failing to expand to a diverse set of functions and activities, MPH graduates may face the same challenges that dental and engineering graduates faced earlier — closure of these colleges and an uncertain future. There is a need for better

management of the demand and supply of public health workforce to address the present deficiency, but also to not end up with over-production of the professionals.

Uniform and inclusive eligibility criteria nationwide need to be established to ensure consistency, transparency, and inclusiveness. The entry criteria for MPH programmes must reflect the field's interdisciplinary nature and include those with health, science, and social science disciplinary backgrounds. Introduction of key foundational courses is critical to ensure that everyone is at the same stage at the start of the course.

India-specific MPH programmes need to be designed while adopting best global practices to address India's disease burden with a focus on primary health care. Public health schools must impart a basic and uniform set of skills and competencies and ensure sufficient time is allocated to acquire these. Adequate exposure to health system and primary health care should be ensured.

Like any professional course, MPH degree needs accreditation systems and councils. A separate Public Health Education Council of India should be set up, which should be an apical, multidisciplinary body that sets standards, accredits programmes, fosters interdisciplinary collaboration, and promotes workforce development.

Public health education in India needs to be anchored in the country's realities to deliver the maximum efficacy.

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{ ABDULLAH ABU SHAWESH } PALESTINE AMBASSADOR TO INDIA

It came in a very critical time... when the health sector in Palestine is in the brink of collapse... and India is one of the country that we reach out to help us

On the upcoming hospital being built by India in the West Bank

India's photographic identity: Who gets to tell this tale?

We have arrived at the 80th Independence Day, and World Photography Day, first proposed by OP Sharma, a Delhi-based photography teacher, is observed in the same month. Independence was also a claim to authorship, a newly independent country deciding it would no longer be described by somebody else's visual storytelling.

Photography arrived in India in 1840, and for decades after, its record was largely made by people who did not live inside the country, and what got published was rarely made by an Indian photographer. It is worth asking whether the work of reclaiming authorship is finished, or whether it has changed shape into something harder to see.

On the surface, the answer seems to be yes, since a billion phones here now produce a huge share of the world's daily picture-making. But volume is never the same thing as authorship. This isn't about copyright, nobody's ownership of the image itself is in question. A country can photograph its own people more than at any point in its history and still not own the image of itself that actually circulates in the world's mind. What's actually at stake is whose picture of India gets noticed, whose name travels with it, and whose gets left out. Deciding which picture of India becomes the picture of India no longer sits with an editor in Delhi or London. It sits with an algorithm nobody elected, and with the aggregator accounts that have learned to feed it, repackaging images as evidence of a country rather than one person's way of seeing it.

For decades that gaze arrived with a foreign photographer's passport, and Indian photography spent that period contesting it. Raghubir Singh stood as its antithesis, rejecting the inherited monochrome altogether and building a colour vocabulary out of Indian miniature painting instead. He argued that black carried the guilt of the West, tied to death in a way colour never was in India.

Unfortunately, what remains is still the same thing, the Holi celebration, a camel fair in Nagaur, the temple in Puri, or a widow in Vrindavan, and none of it needs a foreign passport now.

Photographer Soham Gupta lived this from the inside. His early work on Calcutta's destitute was criticised as a continuing colonial gaze, made by an Indian in his own city. A culture this saturated, this willing to be

photographed, makes it easy for any algorithm to reward the same spectacle an outsider once had to travel here to find, only this time nobody needs a fixer or a visa to get it.

It's also worth remembering there are photographers resisting the pull of all this. Among them, Gauri Gill, Sohrab Hura, Poulomi Basu, each building something different.

None of this argues for the old gatekeepers coming back, since money, training and access kept most of the country out for decades. Responsibility has simply moved to whoever holds the phone.

The test is not whether a picture is well composed. It is whether you are actually interested in telling something through it, or only about making your presence felt. A ladder left lying flat against a soot-blackened wall, something small and dried caught between its rungs, is not the kind of photograph anyone posts under a festival's name. It asks nothing of the viewer except to notice it was there. Nothing decorative does that.

Most of us are too shy to walk up to a stranger with a camera, but a great many of us sit next to one every week without noticing, an Uber driver, the drive and conversation grant access a stranger on the street never would, and there is your portrait, ready-made. Ask permission once, keep it simple, and repeat it ride after ride until it becomes a whole body of work. An algorithm trained to reward a single striking frame has no real appetite for that.

The real reward for a photographer is making a story, not feeding a formula that has run for over a century now. And most of the time, that's exactly what we end up doing, without even noticing.

Independent India started finding its own photography identity, but that search isn't finished. The question still remains whether current image-making amounts to real ownership or only to volume. No algorithm, no platform is going to decide that for us. It gets decided the ordinary way, one story at a time, by whoever bothers to actually look before hitting that shutter, and by how many times they are willing to go back to it.

Samar Jodha is a transdisciplinary artist, photographer and TED speaker, and an advisor to Museo Camera, the photography museum and archive in Gurugram. The views expressed are personal

Gulf nations warned against helping US

Agence France-Presse
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TEHRAN: Iran's armed forces warned Gulf countries against assisting the US military on Wednesday, hours after the United Arab Emirates announced it was severing economic ties with Tehran following new attacks on shipping.

The Gulf is dotted with US military installations, including in the UAE, which said on Tuesday that Iran had fired two ballistic missiles at vessels off its coast.

Despite a recent lull in hostilities between the United States and Iran, the Strait of Hormuz — which Tehran has blockaded — remains a flashpoint, and attacks on commercial ships have continued. A framework US-Iran deal aimed at reopening the vital trade corridor collapsed, and although both sides recently said messages were being exchanged, US President Donald Trump on Tuesday insisted talks were off, taunting Iran with a social media post depicting the strait as a "NEW U.S. Territory".

Iranian armed forces chief of staff Ali Abdollahi, according to the Mehr news agency, warned



Aircraft carrier USS Abraham Lincoln which is supporting US military operations in West Asia, conducts a replenishment-at-sea with fleet replenishment oiler USNS Henry J. Kaiser. REUTERS

"any assistance or facilitation provided to the aggressor US military amounts to participation in the US military operation".

The conflict broke out on February 28 with US-Israeli attacks on the Islamic republic, which retaliated with missile and drone strikes across the region.

Since the start of the war, many Middle Eastern countries have said they would not allow the United States to use their territory as a launchpad for attacks, though Abdollahi cast doubt on those promises. "It seems unlikely

that such a large number of military aircraft, particularly refueling aircraft, could be present at regional bases without knowledge of host countries," said Abdollahi, adding Gulf countries "should know that we are fully aware of the situation".

Media outlets have reported that Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates, Kuwait and Bahrain have all hit targets in Iran in retaliation for Tehran's attacks on the Gulf, though the countries have mostly denied the reports.



Hind Rajab

ISRAELI ARMY ADMITS FIRING THAT KILLED HIND RAJAB

Agence France-Presse
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JERUSALEM: The Israeli military on Wednesday admitted its troops fired on a car carrying five-year-old Hind Rajab in Gaza in 2024, saying it had ordered a criminal investigation into the killing which drew international outrage.

Hind Rajab's body was recovered from a car riddled with bullets in Gaza City days after she was last heard from in a desperate, hours-long phone call to the Palestinian Red Crescent on January 29, 2024.

The Israeli military had previously denied its troops were present in the area near the incident.

"Following review of the findings and due to alleged failures in the coordination of the movement of the Palestine Red Crescent ambulance, it has been decided to initiate a criminal investigation of the incident by Military Police Criminal Investigation Division," the military said on Wednesday.

Alongside the Hind Rajab case, the military published reviews into four other high-profile incidents in Gaza, saying it was also launching a criminal probe into the 2025 killings of 15 Palestinians including medics and humanitarian personnel.

Hind Rajab had made the emergency call after her family's car came under fire during an attempt to flee Gaza City amid an Israeli advance in the Palestinian territory's north. Her body was eventually recovered along with those of six relatives and two Red Crescent rescue workers sent to find her.

Dozen protesting Indian students now potentially can't enter Canada

Anirudh Bhattacharyya
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TORONTO: Canadian border agents deemed a dozen Indian students potentially inadmissible to Canada under the country's immigration and refugee protection law after checking the status of 20 of them at a protest in Calgary in the western province of Alberta, a Canada Border Services Agency (CBSA) spokesperson said on Tuesday.

About 1,500 students at Calgary's Portage College began a demonstration and hunger strike on July 24 against the retroactive rejection and cancellation of their post-graduation work permits. Hundreds of students from India have been refused these permits because they enrolled in non-credit courses that did not provide a certificate, diploma, or a degree. The permit denial put their immigration status in limbo. The denial followed an



Students protesting in Calgary, Canada in late July. RED FM CALGARY

updated policy by Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada (IRCC) that retroactively disqualified graduates of "non-credit" college programmes. IRCC is the department in charge of immigration, refugees, and citizenship.

The CBSA spokesperson told The Globe and Mail newspaper that foreign nationals admitted to Canada are unable to work or

study unless authorised and are expected to depart Canada at the end of their authorised period of stay. "When the CBSA becomes aware of foreign nationals who may be inadmissible to Canada, CBSA officers will investigate and take appropriate action."

The Globe and Mail reported that Calgary Police asked CBSA to conduct a "status check" on four people at the protest and subsequently found that two of them were not in compliance with their immigration status.

Immigration lawyer Sumit Sen said such international students face the prospect of returning home after a shattered dream. He added that the question remains whether IRCC has the power to implement a rule that applies retroactively. The presence of border agents at the protest venue was unprecedented in recent Canadian history. Videos of the CBSA agents at the site were posted on social media.

U.S., CANADA SAY THEY ARE CLOSE TO FINAL TRADE DEAL

Agence France-Presse
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WASHINGTON: The US and Canada signalled on Wednesday that they were close to finalising a comprehensive trade deal, after President Donald Trump paused implementing a new round of crippling tariffs. "We've come to a deal with Canada," Trump said on Wednesday, adding that it's "subject to finalisation of documents".

Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney remained more cautious, saying on social media that Ottawa and Washington "are now moving towards an agreement".

The planned US tariffs, set at 50% percent, were originally due to take effect Wednesday on select Canadian goods.

But Trump announced late Tuesday that he would delay their rollout by three days as both sides worked to finalise a deal.

HARVARD TO PAY \$53 MILLION AFTER MORGUE MANAGER SOLD BODY PARTS

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WASHINGTON: Harvard University has agreed to pay a \$53 million settlement to resolve lawsuits by families after its former morgue manager stole and sold body parts donated for scientific research, with a Boston court reportedly approving the plan on Tuesday.

Cedric Lodge, who managed the morgue at the Harvard Medical School before being fired in 2023, was sentenced to eight years in prison in December. Investigators said Lodge and his wife took body parts from the school "without the knowledge or permission of his employer; the donor, or the donor's family" and shipped them to buyers in other states since 2018.

The Harvard Medical School will set up an annual scholarship starting in the 2027-28 academic year "in appreciation and in honour of all of our anatomical donors."

US Green Card seekers to face broader scrutiny from Sept 18

Press Trust of India
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WASHINGTON: Immigrants seeking Green Cards or permanent residency in the US will face fresh hurdles as the Trump administration has expanded the definition of "public charge" to deny applications to those availing benefits such as Medicaid, food stamps or any subsistence aid from the government.

The new rule finalised by the US Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS) comes into effect from September 18 and will also hit Indians seeking Green Cards.

An earlier rule only considered two types of public benefits as grounds for denying a Green Card application: cash assistance for income maintenance and long-term institutionalisation at the government's expense. "To make public charge inad-

missibility determinations, USCIS officers will consider the five statutory factors and any other factor relevant to assessing the alien's likelihood at any time of becoming a public charge, including the alien's receipt of means-tested public benefits, such as cash assistance for income maintenance, housing assistance, food stamps, financial aid for college, or any other similar benefit," an official statement said.

The guidance follows the Department of Homeland Security's decision to rescind the 2022 Biden-era public charge regulations. The final rule was announced on July 16 and published in the Federal Register on July 20.

It will apply to Forms I-485 seeking permanent residence or adjustment of status that are postmarked or electronically submitted on or after September

18. The new rule allows USCIS officers to count age, health, family status, finances, educational background, and even the use of public benefits by an applicant's dependants, regardless of that dependant's status, against that applicant's chances for approval.

If a USCIS officer finds that an alien applying for adjustment of status to that of a lawful permanent resident in the United States is inadmissible only because they are likely at any time to become a public charge, the USCIS officer may invite the alien to post a public charge bond.

Of the nearly 1.2 million people who received a Green Card in 2023, about 78,100 (6.5%) were from India.

That year, 60% of Indians who received a Green Card did so either as an immediate relative of a US citizen or Green Card holder or as another family member of a citizen.

Trump says will meet North Korean leader

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump said on Wednesday he would meet North Korean leader Kim Jong-un later this year, in what would be their first encounter of Trump's second term. "Yeah, I will be," Trump when asked if he planned to meet Kim. AFP

Pak govt seeks review of Imran Khan order
ISLAMABAD: The Pakistan government on Wednesday petitioned the Supreme

Court, seeking a review and recall of its order to shift jailed former prime minister Imran Khan to a private hospital. PTI

Indian student injured in drone attack in Russia

MOSCOW: An Indian student in Russia sustained minor injuries in a Ukrainian drone attack on Wednesday and is undergoing treatment at a hospital, the Indian Embassy in Moscow said.

The Indian national was identified as a student at the Bashkir State Medical University in Ufa.

Thousands of Indian students go to Russia for higher education every year - most of them to pursue medical courses. PTI

Gold mine collapse kills 100 people in CAR

BOUAR: A landslide at an illegal gold mine has killed at least 100 people in the Central African Republic (CAR) on the border with Cameroon on Tuesday.

The incident occurred at the Zamboye mining site, about 50km from the Central African town of Baboua, on Tuesday. n its path. AFP

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EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



SEBI eyes changes in CAS, SME listing

Apoorva Ajith

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MUMBAI: The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) is pushing ahead with a set of changes meant to smooth out trading on the stock exchanges, with one affecting how orders are placed in the final minutes of each trading day, and the other targeting the rules that govern small and medium enterprise (SME) listings.

From September, stockbrokers will be able to accept trade orders during the first few minutes of the closing auction session (CAS), the window at the day's end when the exchange sets the final closing price for a stock, two people in the know told *Mint*.

"Starting September, we will begin accepting aftermarket orders between 3:15 and 3:20 pm. The move is expected to improve price discovery and liquidity in CAS," said Dhiraj Relli, managing director and chief executive officer at HDFC Securities.

The first 5 minutes of the 20-minute CAS are dedicated to calculating the reference price and transitioning to the auction system. CAS begins at 3:15pm and ends at 3:35pm.

The acceptance of after-market orders will help discover pri-



SEBI wants to smooth out trading on exchanges.

REUTERS

ces more accurately as liquidity improves.

Separately, the markets regulator is considering a change to the rules for the SME segment—the part of the market where smaller companies raise money and list their shares, typically with lighter compliance requirements than those on the main exchange boards.

The review comes as the regulator grapples with a market-making framework that has failed to deliver enough liquidity while adding costs for companies, and with trading rules that can leave investors holding shares they cannot easily sell.

"The market-making framework is not working properly.

And the cost is increasing due to that market-making. The underwriting system is not working. And it should be given a lot of cost. So it is becoming more costly than the main board," SEBI chair Tuhin Kanta Pandey said at an event on Wednesday. Under the market-making framework, designated intermediaries are required to continuously provide buy and sell quotes for a stock, helping support liquidity and smoother trading.

The changes are being considered as part of a thematic review of the SME framework. At its board meet in June, SEBI okayed an assessment of the framework for capital raised by SMEs in the stock market for FY27.

Two cos barred over manipulation in CAS

Apoorva Ajith

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MUMBAI: The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has barred Cophall Mauritius Investment Ltd and Mansi Share and Stock Broking Pvt. Ltd from accessing the securities market and ordered them to deposit a combined ₹3.68 crore over alleged manipulative trading during a Sensex closing auction session (CAS). This is the first time SEBI has launched formal proceedings against any entity trading in the auction session.

In an ex-parte interim order issued on Wednesday, the market regulator said that the two entities had manipulated the CAS on August 13, which was a weekly Sensex expiry day for derivatives contracts on the bourse. Cophall has allegedly made an illegal gain of ₹2.96 crore while Mansi Share made unlawful profits of ₹71.65 lakh.

Per the order, on the weekly Sensex expiry day of August 13, SEBI spotted three sharp spikes in the indicative equilibrium

price. Sensex rose 362 points in two seconds, 132.67 points in 12 seconds and another 405.08 points in 28 seconds.

The order logs showed that Cophall was behind most of the aggressive buying. During the first spike, it accounted for 99.91% of the ₹66.64 crore buy-order value, placing orders across all Sensex constituents at prices around 3% above their reference prices.

It repeated the strategy during the later spikes, accounting for 96.09% and 85.21% of buy-order value, respectively. It subsequently cancelled ₹98.12 crore of buy orders across 30 stocks.

Mansi took the opposite approach. It placed 12.65 lakh shares worth ₹143.44 crore in sell orders across eight Sensex stocks at prices below reference levels, then cancelled the entire block within four seconds.

SEBI said the orders appeared intended to suppress the index, with their cancellation triggering a 232.96-point surge in the IEP.

RBI leaves rate path open as inflation rises

Subhana Shaikh

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MUMBAI: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) held its policy rate steady even as retail inflation has risen steadily in recent months, with governor Sanjay Malhotra signalling that the central bank has left open the direction of its next rate move, depending on how persistent the price pressures prove to be, the minutes of the August policy meeting, released on Wednesday, showed.

Retail inflation rose from 2.74% in January to 4.45% in July, with food and fuel prices driving much of the recent increase. Yet, the RBI's monetary policy committee (MPC) kept the repo rate unchanged at 5.25% at its August 5 meeting, choosing to wait for greater clarity on whether the rise in inflation will persist or become broad-based.

"I would prefer to wait for more certainty to emerge on the inflation trajectory in terms of the persistence of realized prints at these or higher levels, the forecast, and the likely levels to which inflation may normalize and settle for any recalibration of the policy rate," he said.



RBI governor Sanjay Malhotra.

REUTERS

He also cautioned the central bank would need to remain vigilant to risks from food, fuel and other input prices feeding into broader inflation. "Any evidence of these risks materializing may need policy tightening," the governor said in his statement recorded in the minutes.

Malhotra himself had voted to keep the repo rate unchanged at 5.25% and to retain the 'neutral' stance on August 5.

Headline inflation has averaged 3.93% from January to July this year, while core inflation, which excludes volatile food and fuel components and better reflects underlying demand, stood at 3.9% in July, against an expectation of 4.08%.

Core inflation is expected to

converge with headline inflation in the final quarter of this fiscal year, which may suggest a recalibration of the policy rate. The central bank has projected core inflation to average 4.3% in fiscal year 2027 (FY27).

As per Malhotra, the current rise in headline inflation was primarily supply-driven, with higher food and fuel prices accounting for much of the increase. He said there were limited signs of generalization of inflation, while core inflation remained modest and inflation expectations were contained. He said inflation was expected to peak in the third quarter before moderating, while the economy remained resilient despite external headwinds.

The RBI's retail inflation projection for FY27 has been revised downwards by 10 basis points to 5% compared to 5.1% made in the June policy, and its GDP growth projection has been raised by 10 basis points (bps) to 6.7% from 6.6% earlier. A hundred bps equals one percentage point.

Other members echoed Malhotra's view on recalibrating policy if inflation pressures persist, while maintaining a pause at the current juncture.

CBI registers case against Gensol, promoters over fund diversion

Neeraj Chauhan

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NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has registered a case against Gensol Engineering Ltd (GEL), its promoters Anmol Singh Jaggi and Puneet Singh Jaggi, and others for alleged misutilisation and diversion of funds borrowed from the Indian Renewable Energy Development Agency Ltd (IREDA).

The first information report (FIR), filed on July 31, also names sister concern Gensol EV Lease Ltd and unidentified persons.

HT had reported on August 5 last year that probes into alleged financial irregularities at Gensol would be handed over to the CBI. The case was initially being investigated by the Delhi Police. The ED is also conducting a parallel money-laundering investigation against the Jaggis. The CBI case follows findings by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) and IREDA concerning the alleged diversion of funds raised for the purchase of electric vehicles (EVs).

Per IREDA's complaint, which forms part of the CBI FIR, the

agency "suffered a loss of ₹453 crore (principal outstanding as on June 30, 2026) on account of Gensol Engineering Ltd and ₹218.97 crore on account of Gensol EV Lease Ltd, excluding interest and other applicable charges". An internal probe by IREDA found alleged forgery, misrepresentation and submission of false information to credit rating agencies by Gensol, besides diversion of loan funds from their sanctioned purpose, per the complaint.

An email query to Gensol remained unanswered.

SpiceJet, lessor fined ₹15 lakh for wasting NCLT's time

Yash Tiwari & Dipali Banka

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MUMBAI: Debt-laden carrier SpiceJet and aircraft lessor Aviator ML 29641 Ltd were fined a combined ₹15 lakh by the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) on Wednesday for informing the tribunal about their settlement at the last minute, after orders had been reserved in eight insolvency petitions against SpiceJet.

The tribunal directed SpiceJet and Aviator ML to pay ₹7.5 lakh each to the Prime Minister's National Relief Fund.

The NCLT's special bench, comprising judicial member

Mahendra Khandelwal and technical member Anu Jagmohan Singh, passed the oral order on Wednesday.

"Payment of cost of ₹15 lakh payable equally by the operational creditor (Aviator ML) and corporate debtor (SpiceJet), that is ₹7.5 lakh each, to be deposited in the Prime Minister National Relief Fund, within a period of 7 days from today," the bench said.

Taking cognizance of the manner in which SpiceJet informed the tribunal about the settlement on the day the order was due to be pronounced, the bench expressed its displeasure, saying, "It is a fraud played with



SpiceJet is facing eight insolvency petitions.

HT

the bench."

The insolvency court had earlier reserved orders in eight insolvency petitions against the airline. The bench said one of its members was demitting office on Wednesday and there was not enough time to prepare detailed

orders. It therefore de-reserved the matters and directed that they be placed before the regular bench for further consideration.

"There is no option left with us except to de-reserve order...matter may be placed before the regular bench which will consider the matter," the bench said.

"We view the order as a positive step towards resolving the outstanding matters and remain committed to working closely and constructively with our partners to find mutually acceptable solutions," a SpiceJet spokesperson told *Mint*.

The timing of the disclosure

angered the tribunal because the matters had already been reserved for pronouncement. The bench questioned why the development had not been communicated earlier.

This is not the first time the NCLT has raised concerns over SpiceJet's insolvency proceedings. *Mint* reported in December 2024 that the tribunal had observed that the insolvency forum was being used to leverage settlements with the airline.

Since 2023, SpiceJet has faced more than 20 insolvency petitions, although several cases have ended in settlements with creditors and aircraft lessors.

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EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



SURVEY: INDIA LEAST-FAVoured MARKET IN ASIA

India has replaced Indonesia as Asia's least-preferred stock market in a survey of fund managers by Bank of America Corp., signalling growing wary toward a market that's among the world's worst performers this year.

The lack of a clear AI exposure remains the key concern for Indian equities, with weak growth emerging as the next most important risk, per the survey, which showed 32% of the respondents were net underweight on the nation.

Lack of reforms and high valuations also emerged as reasons for the bearish outlook on Asia's fourth-largest equity market.

In contrast, sentiment rose for Indonesia, with 27% of the fund managers saying they were net underweight on the market, compared with 32% in July.

Taiwan and Japan remain investors' most preferred regions.

BLOOMBERG

AUTO-HEADLAMPS MUST BE AT LOW BEAM: DRAFT RULES

Soumya Chatterjee

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NEW DELHI: Automatic headlamps should operate only in the passing beam level, commonly known as low-beam, from April 1, 2028, under draft rules proposed by the Union ministry of road transport and highways, along with multiple road-safety measures covering the visibility of buses, tractors, construction vehicles and others.

These draft amendments to the Central Motor Vehicles Rules were published on Wednesday and is open to suggestions and objections from the public.

Among the proposed changes, medium-distance (Type II) and long-distance (Type III) buses would have to carry reflective markings around the rear of the vehicle from April 1, 2028. The markings would have to meet updated requirements for their size, installation and performance under AIS standards.

The draft extends updated requirements for reflective devices to construction equipment vehicles, combine harvesters and tractors, which would have to meet the performance requirements of AIS-200:2025.

{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

ACROSS

- Complaint of the motorist using too much petrol? (11)
- I managed to name a Persian (7)
- Fall in production of plums (5)
- Turns and leaves (4)
- More of the same in Latin (2,6)
- Change roles? (6)
- Prosecuted about it but satisfied (6)
- Peer's son gives wrong answers (8)
- Before midday the doc gets shot (4)
- No permission for recesses (5)
- A group on leave (7)
- This form of state aid can be rather remote (2,1,8)

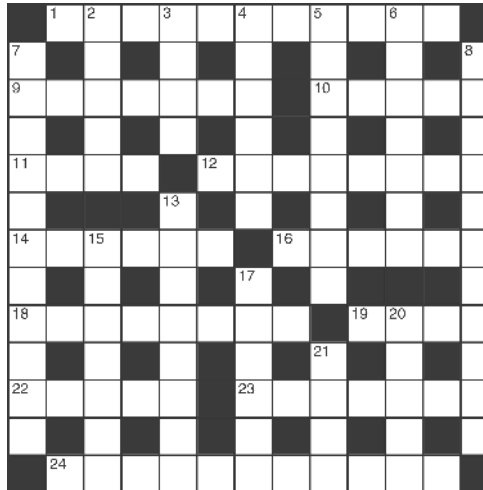
DOWN

- Gold blend tea in spout (5)
- Take off the garment right away (4)
- Time taken by a secretary (6)
- Fault set right and proper (8)
- By endless work advanced to become rich (7)
- An offhand impression (11)
- Vicissitudes rarely encountered in Holland (3,3,5)
- Married in the old-fashioned way (8)
- Get rid of players on strike (4,3)
- Awards given for zero marks (6)
- Italian bankers I left to become a doctor (5)
- A delay cuts back the celebration (4)

YESTERDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17568)



PUZZLE 17569 © Gemini Crosswords 2018 All rights reserved



QUICK CLUES

ACROSS

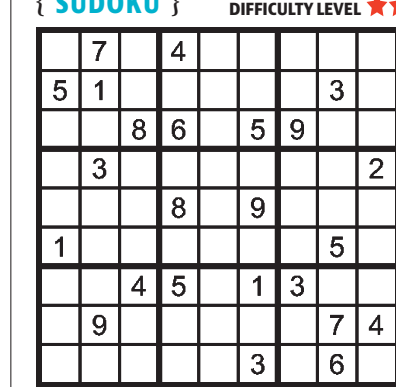
- An unsuccessful venture (4,7)
- Precise moment (7)
- A minor planet (5)
- Change direction (4)
- Return from investment (8)
- Renounce as erroneous (6)
- Defeated (6)
- Rules of diplomatic etiquette (8)
- To loose (4)
- A narcotic drug (5)
- Baffle (7)
- Emergency food supplies (4,7)

DOWN

- Happen afterwards (5)
- Cheerless (4)
- Achieve (6)
- Unevenly balanced (8)
- Ostentatiously rich (7)
- Expectation of inherited wealth (6,5)
- Continuing source of profit (6,5)
- Not often found (8)
- Bishop's staff of office (7)
- Part of the eye (6)
- A synthetic polymer (5)
- Person opposed to a policy (4)

{ SUDOKU }

DIFFICULTY LEVEL ★★★★★



Fill in all the squares in the grid so that each row, column and each of the 9x9 squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9.



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{ WEATHER }

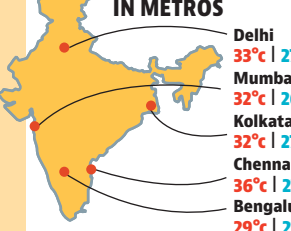
TEMPERATURE • HIGH • LOW

THURSDAY Generally cloudy sky with light rain or drizzle	FRIDAY Generally cloudy sky with light rain or drizzle	SATURDAY Generally cloudy sky with light rain or drizzle
29°C 21°C	29°C 20°C	29°C 20°C

ALMANAC

Today is 20th August 2026
• 06 Rabi ul Awwal, 1448
• 23 Shrawana, Shukla Paksha, 08
• Samvat: 2083
• Sunset: Thursday at 06:38 p.m.
• Sunrise: Friday at 06:08 a.m.
• Moonrise: Thursday at 12:33 p.m.
• Moonset: Friday at 12:04 a.m.

TEMPERATURE IN METROS



SPORT



Musiala collapses again during match

BERLIN: Jamal Musiala's readiness for Bayern Munich's start to the season is in question after collapsing in consecutive warmup games because of a neurological issue. The 23-year-old went down shortly after entering the field in a friendly against Heidenheim on Tuesday, three days after a similar incident against Leipzig. Musiala said he has been diagnosed with "brief, temporary, but easily treatable absence seizures caused by a neurological dysfunction".

Pragg qualifies for Grand Tour final

ST. LOUIS: Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa beat Maxime Vachier-Lagrave of France to jump to joint lead alongside Wesley So after the eighth round of the Sinquefeld Cup. The victory took Pragg to five points out of a possible eight and the Indian is now assured of a place in the Grand finale scheduled later this year.

Duleep Trophy final moved to Chennai

NEW DELHI: The final of the Duleep Trophy 2026-27 has been shifted from the CoE in Bengaluru to the MA Chidambaram Stadium in Chennai from Sept 6 to 10. Duleep Trophy is scheduled to start on Aug 23.

Pakistan bundled out for 171 on Day 1

LONDON: Ollie Robinson and Josh Tongue took five wickets each as England made a strong start to the post-Bazball era by dismissing Pakistan for 171 in the first Test at Headingley. Robinson bagged 5/51 while Tongue took 5/46. From 117/3, Pakistan lost their last seven wickets for 54 runs.

Goals flow as India down Pak to enter second stage

Rutvik Mehta
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MUMBAI: India versus Pakistan in hockey may have ceased to be a rivalry, going strictly by the term's definition and the predictability of the eventual outcome. What it still does often manage to deliver, however, is goals. And a fair few of them.

Eight is what the Men's World Cup clash at the Wagener Hockey Stadium in Amstelveen, Netherlands, brought along on Wednesday. That goal volume was exactly the same as the last time the two neighbours met in the Pro League in June (7-1 India), and one better than the fixture before that (4-3 India).

Also better, for a change, was the competitiveness. India won like they were expected to, and with it advanced to the next stage of this new-format World Cup. But in their 5-3 victory India did not run all over Pakistan, like they did in their last Pro League encounter, or at the last Asian Games where the 10-2 scoreline reflected the gulf between the two traditional hockey powerhouses.

It appeared to be headed that way even in this rare India-Pakistan contest in a World Cup, where the last time Pakistan beat India was four decades ago. Setting the tone for a frenetic tussle with intensity and intent, the men in saffron were up 2-0 in 10 minutes and 3-0 in 20.

The men in white and green, finishing off a lot better than they began, though did not let it slip into one-way traffic territory, and came up with enough speed-bumps for India to make it 4-2 at half-time and 5-3 at the end.

An extended fist bump along with a little jump and a loud "Cmon" was Harmanpreet Singh's way of celebrating their second victory in this World Cup that was more essential and emotional. It ensured that India, coming off the 4-2 defeat to England, progressed



India players celebrate after scoring against Pakistan during their FIH World Cup Pool D match in Amstelveen.

to the next round as the second-best team from Pool D.

The captain was again at the forefront of the team's set-piece returns, flicking and sweeping goals from two penalty corners (PC) in the 5th minute and 21st minute. Yet it was Abhishek's individual brilliance and craftsmanship leading to two quality field goals (11th, 24th) that was the standout, and that India would need more of going deeper into the tournament.

Hardik Singh got India's fifth goal through a penalty stroke in the 35th minute, after a period where Pakistan grew into the battle and got on the board through

Hannan Shahid's field goal (22nd) and Sufyan Khan's PC (24th). Shahid kicked off the final quarter with another strike (46th) that threatened to take India down the path of the 4-3 Pro League game in which Pakistan hit two late goals. India held on here, despite going down to 10 men for the majority of the final five minutes.

Errors of such kind would be somewhat concerning for coach Craig Fulton as they run into stronger opponents. As will India's control on the ball and defensive structure that met rocky waters after a smooth start.

"These games can go like that. We've got to do a better job of controlling that," Fulton said in his half-time assessment. "We need to be better on the ball, and stop the turnovers."

After the captain got his day's

second - this time after a PC innovation, save, rebound and a pass got him to belatedly sweep the ball into goal instead of flick it right through - it was time for Abhishek's solo show again. Attacking from the left, the 27-year-old made the Pakistani defence dance to his tunes, dribbling, circling, swerving and tricking multiple white jerseys while engineering another delightful field goal.

Abhishek's superb display, to go with Harmanpreet (five goals in three games) already going better than his entire 2023 World Cup tally, were the biggest takeaways for India. That the team stuttered in phases yet again, and let slip three goals, remains a critical area to improve for its semi-final ambitions.

The two men were at it again six minutes later. A clever high ball from Harmanpreet was taken down with aplomb inside the circle by Abhishek, who quickly directed it towards the Pakistani goal.

After the captain got his day's

DPL: South Delhi defeat North Delhi

HT Correspondent

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NEW DELHI: South Delhi Superstarz secured a thrilling four-wicket victory over North Delhi Strikers in the Delhi Premier League 2026 at the Arun Jaitley Stadium in the afternoon fixture on Wednesday.

Skipper Ayush Badoni starred with a superb 90 off 47 to help his team chase down 208 against Strikers. South Delhi slipped to 50/3 before Badoni launched a remarkable counterattack.

He joined hands with wicket-keeper batter Tejasvi Dahiya, who scored 28 off 19 balls, to steady the chase.

Badoni continued to dominate despite wickets falling around him, producing a superb knock to keep South Delhi within reach of victory. His dismissal, edging Ajay Yadav to the wicketkeeper, left the Superstarz needing nine runs from the final over.

Ankit Dabas then delivered under pressure, launching the first ball for six before calmly completing the chase. He remained unbeaten on 26 off 10



Ayush Badoni.

DDCA

balls as South Delhi reached the target with three deliveries to spare.

Earlier, North Delhi posted 207/9 in 20 overs, powered by a blistering opening stand between in-form captain Sarthak Ranjan and Yash Dabas. Sarthak struck 45 off 23 balls, while Yash Dabas smashed 78 from just 38 deliveries as the pair added 107 runs for the first wicket.

Sarthak's dismissal triggered a series of wickets, but Arjun Rapria provided a late flourish with a rapid 27 off 11 balls to take North Delhi beyond 200. For South Delhi, Divansh Rawat was the pick of the bowlers with 3/22, while Ankit Dabas claimed 2/18.

Sports ministry backs trimmed Arjuna list

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NEW DELHI: A day after it announced a trimmed-down list of national sports awardees, the sports ministry backed its decision and said awards can't be doled out on reputation alone.

Only 17 athletes were named for Arjuna Awards from the 24 recommended by the selection committee led by former Supreme Court judge Justice (ret'd) Arun Kumar Mishra. The shortlist was submitted at least six months back, and the ministry, after a prolonged evaluation, pruned the list.

"We agree it's not the convention," a senior ministry official

said. "Usually, the names forwarded by the panel are final, but this time we decided to cut the flab. Arjuna Awards have to be earned, they can't be given on reputation." The ministry has the final say on awards and "may continue to exercise its right in future," the official added.

No athlete was named for Major Dhyan Chand Khel Ratna, India's highest sporting honour, for 2025. For the first time since 2014, Khel Ratna will not be awarded. "We wanted to preserve the integrity of the awards. These awards can't be given for the sake of it. The committee's recommendations are not binding on the ministry."

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Suthar takes 10, India boost WTC hopes

India win in their 600th Test by 165 runs vs SL, pocket 12 points to stay in the run for the WTC final

Somshuvra Laha

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KOLKATA: Manav Suthar picked up 10 wickets as India defeated Sri Lanka by 165 runs at Galle on Wednesday, ensuring the visitors can look back at their 600th Test with fond memories. This was the left-arm spinner's second five-wicket haul as India secured 12 World Test Championship points to keep them firmly in the race for next year's final, while Sri Lanka were left to contemplate how quickly a promising position had become a heavy defeat.

This was India's fifth win in 10 Tests in the current WTC cycle and their first victory since they beat West Indies in Ahmedabad last year. India's PCT increased from 48.14 to 53.33 after the win. However, they remain fifth in the WTC standings, behind Australia (77.77), South Africa (75.00), New Zealand (72.22) and Bangladesh (66.67).

India have one more Test left in the Sri Lanka series before travelling to New Zealand for a two-Test series. Their WTC campaign will end with a five-Test Border-Gavaskar Trophy series against Australia at home next year.

If India manage to win all eight remaining Tests, their final points percentage could reach 74.07%, which would put them in an excellent position to make the final.

Resuming on their overnight score of 84 for four, Sri Lanka moved to 142 before losing two big wickets in the span of 26 balls. The scalp of first innings centurion Sonal Dinusha triggered an extraordinary collapse as Sri Lanka lost the remaining four wickets for just eight runs. It was the kind of culmination India were seeking after getting almost everything right on the go.

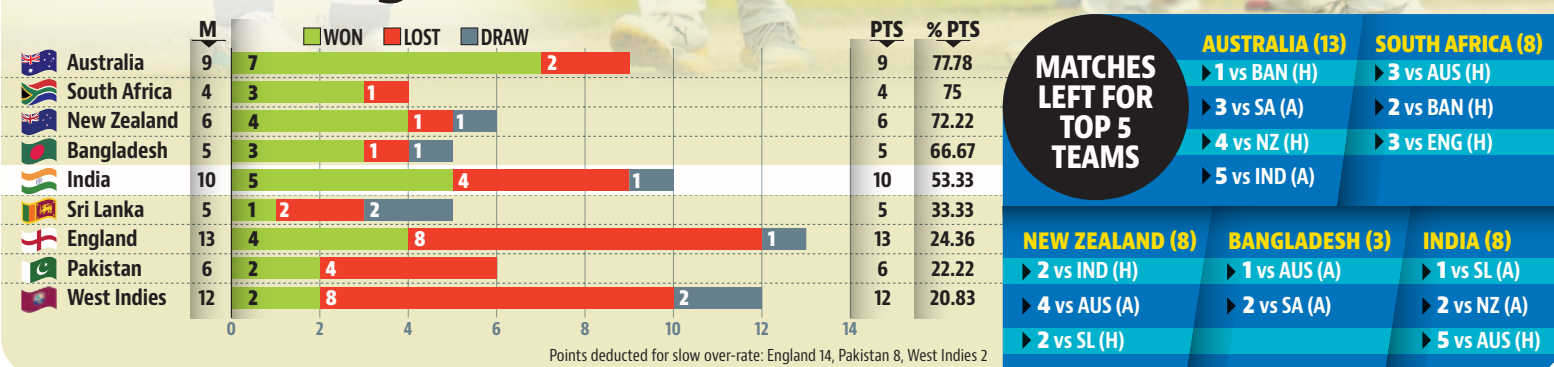
Shubman Gill won the toss and, on a slow surface that offered enough encouragement to spin without turning into a minefield, made the advantage count. Their victory was built initially by a No.3 playing only his third Test and finished by a left-arm spinner playing his second.

Devdutt Padikkal's 167 was the foundation. He battled with the authority of a player who appeared to understand exactly what the conditions demanded, resisting the temptation to manufacture scoring opportunities and instead allowing the runs to accumulate. His hundred gave



India's Manav Suthar (C) celebrates after dismissing SL's Prabath Jayasuriya on Day 5 of the first Test in Galle on Wednesday. PTI

WTC standings



SCORECARD

India 1st innings 462

Sri Lanka 1st innings 284

India 2nd innings 193

Sri Lanka 2nd innings (Overnight 84/4)

D de Silva c Suthar b Jadeja 59

S Dinusha c Jurel b Suthar 84

N Dickwella c Pant b Prasidh 10

K Numantha b Suthar 20

P Jayasuriya b Suthar 0

L Kumara c Pant b Suthar 0

A Fernando not out 0

Extras (b 5, lb 1, nb 3) **9**

Total (all out in 774 ovs) **206**

FoW: 1-13, 2-14, 3-21, 4-47, 5-142, 6-156, 7-199, 8-199, 9-199

Bowling: Siraj 9-2-15-1, Suthar 23.4-2-55-6, Prasidh 10-3-16-2, Jadeja 23-3-71-1, Kuldeep 11-0-38-0, Padikkal 1-0-5-0.

India a 178-run first-innings lead but equally crucial was the second innings 44 that provided the spinners a substantial margin for error.

Suthar exploited that beautifully. The most intriguing aspect of his bowling was not simply the amount of turn he generated but his ability to vary it without making his intentions obvious. There was the classical left-arm spinner's delivery—flighted, drifting in, pitching on a teasing length and biting away. But there was also the quicker ball, pushed through at more than 90kph, which arrived before the batter expected it and often straightened. That combination proved devastating.

Sri Lanka's resistance in the final innings had, for a while, seemed to require India to work much harder than the final margin suggests. Dhananjaya de Silva and Sonal Dinusha put together a 95-run partnership from 202 balls, displaying precisely the sort of patience that can frustrate a fourth-innings attack on a pitch that seemed to flatten out. For the first hour, India had little to show for their efforts even as Mohammed Siraj

and Ravindra Jadeja toiled away. Dinusha, who had already made a hundred in the first innings, moved serenely towards another.

He reached 50 with a six off Kuldeep Yadav and appeared destined to become the first Sri Lankan batter to turn the match into a genuine final-day problem for India. Dhananjaya was equally stubborn. He had survived the previous evening after Jadeja overstepped when he had the Sri Lankan captain caught at slip.

This time, however, there was no reprieve. Jadeja broke the partnership in the 56th over, finding the top edge of an uncharacteristic sweep from Dhananjaya and then watching Suthar take the catch at short fine leg.

That was the wicket India needed, but what followed mattered more.

Prasidh Krishna removed Niroshan Dickwella, who had spent

much of his brief stay at the crease trying to manufacture momentum. The conversation between Dickwella and Yashasvi Jaiswal—fielding at close—before the dismissal had provided a lighter interlude. Jaiswal promising to take him to IPL if he attacked the bowling. Dickwella tried, Prasidh Krishna cashed in. That left Sri Lanka's tail exposed, and Suthar did not waste the opportunity.

The 75th over was the decisive burst. Dinusha, having batted for 128 balls and reached 84, finally fell to a soft dismissal, inside-edging a flighted delivery onto his pad and offering a catch at leg gully. Two balls later, Prabath Jayasuriya was bowled by a delivery that gripped and spun past his defensive stroke. Suthar was suddenly on a hat-trick.

He didn't get it, but the manner of the next wicket was revealing. Lahiru Kumara played for turn against a ball that didn't turn. It trimmed the outside edge

and disappeared into Rishabh Pant's gloves, giving Suthar his second five-for in two Tests. Two overs later, he finished the job himself.

There is a temptation to be carried away by a young spinner's numbers, particularly on a Galle surface and against a lower-order exposed to pressure. Yet Suthar's performance suggested something more substantial than favourable circumstances. He showed control and variation, qualities that India will value enormously as the WTC cycle develops.

It is still a long road in their campaign for the World Test Championship final. But this was the sort of win India needed—comprehensive, built around a major first-innings contribution from a young batter, and sealed by another young bowler with a remarkably high bar. In what has been a challenging transition period, that's a laudable start for India.

Subtle variations make Suthar special: KL Rahul

Somshuvra Laha

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KOLKATA: In the game of a bowler posing a question to a batter who must come up with an adequate answer or perish, Manav Suthar can be quite the improviser. And even though two Tests aren't quite enough evidence, the 24-year-old's body of work already demands a nuanced analysis. Three deliveries across three sessions uphold the sentiment that maybe Suthar is for the long haul after all.

The first, to Pasindu Sooriyabandara on the fourth day, was almost a question of geometry. Suthar floated the ball on middle and leg, offered little spin and allowed the delivery to continue on its original trajectory.

Sooriyabandara played for the defensive inside edge; there was none. The ball struck him on the back leg, and after India reviewed the decision, ball-tracking confirmed three reds.

To Sonal Dinusha, who was 16 short of a second century of the match, Suthar went wider, outside leg stump, lighting the ball and inviting the left-hander to manufacture a scoring shot. Dinusha tried to clip it, inside-edged the ball onto his pad and watched it balloon to leg gully.

Then came Prabath Jayasuriya. This time Suthar offered pace and drift—92.7kph, an in-drifting length delivery that appeared to give the left-hander enough line to defend from the back foot. But the ball gripped, turned away just enough to beat the outside edge and crashed into the off stump. Three balls, three different lengths at different speeds, all bearing the same result.

That is perhaps the most persuasive evidence yet that Suthar's value lies not merely in being a left-arm spinner, but in being a spinner who produce different problems with the same action. KL Rahul identified precisely this quality.

"It's the subtle variations from the same action from the same angle," he said, pointing out that Suthar can bowl slower or quicker without noticeably changing his arm speed. "Especially in Galle, with the wind blowing from one side and he used that drift really well, and from there the ball straightens or comes in."

That distinction matters enormously for an orthodox slow left-arm, since the same bowling action can create a leg-before as well as a caught-behind dismissal. The temptation with such bowling is to think in terms of stock deliver-

ies: bowl accurately, wait for the pitch to intervene and hope pressure eventually produces a mistake. Suthar appears to have a more sophisticated proposition. He can make a batter feel that nothing is happening, while constantly changing the terms of engagement.

The numbers after only two Tests are already striking: 17 wickets, two five-wicket hauls, a ten-wicket match haul and a strike rate of 27.2, while conceding just 2.49 runs an over.

These are excellent numbers but the manner of taking the 17 wickets provides a more compelling argument that Suthar possesses the ability to challenge several modes of dismissal from the same corridor.

Rahul's observation is instructive. "I think he's very consistent," he said. "From the same place he just keeps using subtle variations through the day. So the batsmen will also think if he's not moving then I'll have to do something. When you get a batter in that sort of mindset you're winning the contest."

There is another reason for optimism. Suthar hasn't arrived completely unprepared for Test cricket's demands. India's first-class structure has given him a bridge between Ranji Trophy cricket and international cricket through India A tours and exposure to conditions in Australia, Sri Lanka and England. Rahul believes that process matters.

The jump from domestic cricket to Test cricket is enormous, he said, but India's pathway allows players to understand their own games and the expectations of international cricket before receiving the Test cap. Suthar's early returns suggest that education has already taken root.

Badminton Worlds: US teen Tan plots shock exit of Lakshya Sen

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NEW DELHI: On a day when the home crowd at the Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium arrived expecting a routine march into the last 16, India's leading men's singles hope Lakshya Sen fell for a 73-minute Round of 32 exit at the BWF World Championships here on Wednesday.

The 14th seed, who won bronze at this event in 2021, was stunned 19-21, 21-19, 21-17 by 18-year-old American sensation Garret Tan in a physical match that saw dives, falls, medical timeouts and a complete reversal of tactical momentum.

Sen, who came into the tournament seeking to replicate his previous podium exploits, started aggressively. Taking the opening game 21-19, the world No.14 relied on fast front-court coverage and steep, angled half-smashes to keep the athletic American at bay.

But as Tan started using his height to fire booming, downward smashes, neutralising Sen's net speed with heavy backline clears, the script inverted.

Following the gruelling decider, where Sen fought back from 11-4 down to bring the score to 17-16 before errors cost him the final stretch, the Indian required immediate medical attention for bruises sustained from multiple full-court dives before addressing the media.

"It was a very tough match, a hard-fought match. I gave my all, whatever I had in my tank. I was also exhausted physically in the third game," Sen said in the mixed zone. "I will give a lot of credit to him, he played a solid game. I am a little disappointed, though I gave my all in the end it wasn't enough. He was just a better player today."

Addressing his tactical struggles throughout the contest, Sen said that Tan's aggressive length kept him perpetually on the back foot.



US's Garret Tan (R) celebrates after beating Lakshya Sen at the BWF World Championships on Wednesday. SANCHIT KHANNA/HT

"He was quite dominant. I was always playing cover-up. I had my chances, but he was taking the points and I was playing under pressure a lot of times. All the games were close, so I don't think there was any clear advantage," said Sen.

"The rallies were long and the drift was not playing a big role. He was quite solid on his defence and attack, so I wasn't getting many chances. It is a big tournament, so it hurts more, but we have some big tournaments coming up, so I will prepare for those."

The mood in the opposite camp, though, was one of jubilation mixed with awe. Tan, a southern California boy who splits his training between USA and Taiwan, played with a maturity beyond his age and ranking (world No.92), not bothered by a hostile crowd.

Sitting in his corner was an all-female support system featuring coach Paula Lynn and current shuttler Lauren Lam, who lost her women's doubles Round of 32 contest partnering Allison Lee, against Treasa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand on Tuesday.

Lynn said that Tan's ability to maintain focus and handle the pressure here was immensely impressive, praising his dedication as a "hard-working, God-fearing athlete". The match hit a brief moment of concern when Tan dived for the shuttle and bumped his head, experiencing mild dizziness, but his bench stepped in during the pause to

reset his focus.

The coach added that their strategy revolved around slowing down the pace and keeping Sen away from the front court, forcing the Indian to play from the backline. They had prepared Tan mentally to ignore the loud home crowd and control only what was happening on his side of the net.



Kalyan Chaubey with Cape Verde goalkeeper Vozinha. HT

INDIA-CAPE VERDE FRIENDLY MATCH LIKELY ON OCT 6

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KOLKATA: India are likely to play Cape Verde in Kolkata or Kochi on Oct 6. With the match against Brazil scheduled here on Oct 3 and two more away to New Zealand in November, 2026 could be the year India play four matches against teams from the 2026 World Cup, an unprecedented event in the history of the men's team.

"There aren't too many stadiums that meet the requirement of holding a FIFA international. Hence, Kolkata or Kochi," an official at AIFF told HT. AIFF is trying for another friendly before the Brazil game, the official said.

Cape Verde, whose fairytale run in the 2026 World Cup included holding Spain to a 0-0 draw and taking finalists Argentina to extra-time, have named Humberto Bettencourt as head coach following Bubi's exit. They will come to India after AFCON qualifier against Rwanda (Sept 27).

For the Brazil match, five representatives from CBF, the Brazil federation, will reach Kolkata late on Wednesday for a recee.

In other news, another AIFF official said Diamond Harbour FC have failed to meet Wednesday's 2pm deadline to pay ₹66 lakh as the second instalment of their participation fee for the ISL. "It has been decided that this season's ISL will have 13 teams," the official said.

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